

EARTH RESIDENTIAL COMPLEX

A Manifesto of Civilizational Adulthood

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(First Apostle of Common Sense)

2037

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*The hardest thing is not to describe the future, but to explain
how we ended up where we are right now. This book is about how
humanity outgrew its own boundaries, fired its leaders,
and finally got around to fixing its own home.*

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PREFACE

Operating Manual for a House That Forgot to Stop Burning

Dear Resident.

If you're holding this text, then you've noticed it too: in our shared hallway called "the Planet," the light bulbs blow more often than they're replaced, and the bills for "major renovation" keep growing in direct proportion to the number of cracks in the foundation. The Management Company (in the old world they called it "the state") sends invoices with zero useful results but ever-increasing amounts due.

This book is not a call to the barricades. Barricades are what happens when the building's residents fight over whose turn it is to take out the trash. We went further: we fired the doorman, cancelled the management company, and hired a smart intercom. This is an attempt at adult conversation in a kindergarten where the teachers came to blows over whose potty is more "sovereign."

We won't be "staring into the abyss." We'll simply look at the current situation from the outside — the way you look at the ridiculous posture of a party guest who fell asleep and is about to face-plant into the salad. We feel no *schadenfreude* and no fear. We understand.

For your convenience, I've divided this text into three sections.

I. Anamnesis: How We Built a Fence Around Common Sense

A condensed technical report. We'll trace how we went from the hardened children of the Cold War to pampered loners who hate their neighbor — not because he's an enemy, but because he has the "wrong" opinion on the internet. We'll see how the tools of global governance ultimately devoured the human being himself. These are four chapters about how one problem bred the next — like a chain reaction, except instead of nuclear charges, it's human stupidity at industrial scale.

II. The Panorama of Absurdity: The Great Triad of Contractors

We'll examine the condition of our "management companies" — the US, China, and Russia. We'll look at them without anger, more with the professional curiosity of a pathologist. This is a cold analysis of why their old girdles burst at the seams simultaneously. Spoiler: because you cannot sell fear forever in a place where people just need working elevators.

III. Speculative Fever Dream: ERC 'Earth'

The most important section for my friends in the oversight agencies. Everything written here is a product of my imagination — pure fiction. As Plato used to say: "The state is the triumph of justice." I merely imagined what would happen if justice were replaced by efficiency, and leaders replaced by an algorithm. This is utopia, delirium, a tall tale. A world without borders, without enemies, where a latté is paid for with manual labor — obviously impossible. Please treat this section as a collection of jokes for those who like to daydream while watching flies on the ceiling.

We begin. Live as though today is your last — but don't forget the trash won't take itself out.

Welcome to the Earth Residential Complex. Please don't smoke in the hallways of history — there's far too much gunpowder in there.

PART I ANATOMY OF COLLAPSE (2024–2030)

A diagnosis of a system that burned out from the inside.

Before we begin — a short reading guide.

Part I is a single story broken into four acts. Each act flows from the previous one with mathematical inevitability. Here's the whole chain:

Fear united us → the enemy vanished → connections atrophied → algorithms locked people in → institutions quietly rotted → reality crashed through the wall.

The four chapters of this section are not separate essays. They are four links of one chain. When everything finally lurched in 2026, not a single link was accidental — each one followed from the last. That is what makes these events not a tragedy, but a logical outcome.

One more note: as you read, you will meet one family — the Hauers from Dortmund. They are not real people, but their story is completely real. It is the story of any European family that lived through these eighty years.

Chapter 1. A Crash Course in Illness (1945–2026)

Eighty years — that is exactly how long it takes a society to forget why it holds together. The following four sub-chapters chronicle that forgetting.

1.1. The Era of Comprehensible Fears: The Discipline of "The Button" (1945–1991)

The period from 1945 to 1991 looks to us today like a time of strange, almost cosy madness. It was an era when the world resembled a two-room apartment divided by a thin but absolutely impenetrable wall. In one room the wallpaper was red, in the other it was blue, and the residents of each were sincerely convinced that cannibals lived on the other side.

"A prince should have no other aim or thought, nor acquire skill in anything, except war, its organization, and its discipline." — Machiavelli, The Prince

For the first time in history, the "Management Companies" (nation-states) held in their hands an instrument of absolute management — nuclear apocalypse. It was the perfect way to keep residents in line, because it was not virtual but entirely concrete. If your neighbour on the planet's communal kitchen hit the Button, the whole kitchen would be ash in twenty minutes. No exceptions. No negotiations. No appeals.

| Dortmund, 1965.

Werner Hauer, 35, steelworker. He knows every neighbour on his floor by name, knows the names of their children and the stories of their grandmothers. On Friday evenings he and his neighbour Heinrich drink beer in the kitchen — Heinrich votes CDU, Werner votes SPD. That doesn't stop them from digging the vegetable garden together every Saturday. When the Americans announce a nuclear drill, Heinrich knocks on the door himself: "Werner, it's a drill, stay calm." The fear of the Soviet bomb is shared, invisible, like cement in the building's walls.

Werner doesn't think about it in those terms. He simply knows: if it comes to it — survive together. And that "together" defines everything else.

1. The Discipline of the Button and the Management of Fear

The fear of death is the most honest political instrument in history. It requires no persuasion, needs no advertising. It simply exists. A state holding the monopoly on nuclear weapons held the monopoly on the very concept of "security."

— **Survival collectivism:** *You didn't need to be forced to pay taxes or march in parades. You did it voluntarily, because you believed: if you stopped being part of "your side," the "other side" would turn you into radioactive ash. The neighbour in the bomb shelter isn't just a neighbour. He may be the only person who will help you survive. That's why you needed to know his name.*

— **Security in exchange for liberty:** *Politicians sold the most in-demand commodity — survival. It was an honest barter: "We build you bomb shelters and missiles, and you don't ask awkward questions about why the shop only stocks one kind of sausage." Both sides understood the deal. Both sides honoured it.*

2. Clear Enemies: The World as a Chessboard

As Sun Tzu said: "Know your enemy and know yourself, and in a hundred battles you will never be in peril." The problem was that in 1945–1991, you didn't need to know the enemy — you just needed to have one. The enemy was not a specific person or state, but a principle, a function. He was needed not to fight, but to explain everything else.

Parameter	The "Reds" System	The "Blues" System
Primary incentive	A bright future (ideology)	Free consumption (capital)
Control instrument	Party loyalty	Financial success
Answer to any crisis	"Enemy sabotage"	"The communist threat"
Common foundation	Fear of the Button	Fear of the Button

Both systems were mirror images of each other. Both needed an enemy like oxygen. Both produced citizens who knew their neighbours, because tomorrow they might have to shelter together.

3. The State as Strict Parent

We were children who feared the dark, and the state happily took on the role of the father with a belt. It decided what music we could hear, where we could holiday, and what we could dream of. But it also fixed the elevators, built hospitals, and knew what would happen next year.

This was the golden age of statehood. Politicians would never again have such total control over minds — because never again would the threat be so simple and visible. The Button was the only god in whom everyone believed — from Washington to Moscow. And that god, strange as it may seem, kept the world in order.

Analytical conclusion: The era of 1945–1991 taught humanity one dangerous habit: assuming that order is only possible when there is an external enemy. We grew accustomed to survival collectivism and forgot what creative collectivism looks like. The politicians of that era were not creators — they were salesmen of fear. And when the wall fell in 1991, it turned out that without the image of an enemy, the "parents" had absolutely no idea what to do with their grown-up and bewildered children.

Transition mechanism: *The enemy vanished — and so did the rationale for "together." The state offered a substitute: consumption. Not "live for your country" — but "live for your next purchase." It looked like liberation. In reality, it was swapping one adhesive for another — and the new one was significantly weaker.*

1.2. The Illusion of "The End of History": The Supermarket Instead of Meaning (1991–2010)

In 1991 the wall fell, and the world held its breath in euphoria. We were told that history had ended: one "operating system" had won, so now gardens of democracy would bloom everywhere and the smell of fresh hamburgers would fill the air. Political scientist Francis Fukuyama wrote exactly that — "The End of History." He later apologised. But it was too late.

*"With the exception of the instinct of self-preservation, the propensity for emulation is probably the strongest and most persistent of economic motives."
— Thorstein Veblen, The Theory of the Leisure Class (1899)*

Politicians across the world understood: if you can no longer frighten people with the nuclear Button, you have to bury them in things. And if you can't bury them — give them credit, so they bury themselves.

| **Dortmund, 1997.**

Klaus Hauer, Werner's son, 32, office manager. He has his first credit card and his first trip to Barcelona without standing in line at the consulate. The Berlin Wall fell eight years ago — and the world has become boundless. Klaus doesn't know his neighbours: people in his building change every eighteen months. Why bother getting acquainted? There's work, there's the television, there's an instalment plan for a new fridge. The neighbour to the left — looks Polish. Or Slovak. A decent fellow, says hello. Klaus doesn't know his name.

Werner calls his son every week. "Klaus, how are you over there, getting on all right with the neighbours?" — "Dad, everything's fine, what are you on about?" Werner puts down the receiver and stares out of the window for a long time.

1. The Great Barter: Fear Exchanged for Credit

— **GDP as the new religion:** *Politicians stopped measuring themselves in warheads and started measuring themselves in GDP graphs. Behind those figures lay emptiness. We were sold consumption growth as the only meaning of existence. If the economy is growing — everything's fine. If you're unhappy — you're simply not consuming enough. Buy more.*

— **The dismantling of connections:** *These were the years when what sociologists would call "the great loneliness" began. Survival collectivism — when you knew your neighbour because you would shelter with him in a bomb raid — gave way to atomised consumption. Why do I need to know my neighbour when I have a credit card, an online shop, and pizza delivery?*

2. The Mortgage as an Instrument of Silence

— **Credit as a straitjacket:** *A person weighed down with debt for a car, a house, and a package holiday in Turkey is the most docile citizen in the world. He won't go to the barricades. He won't ask awkward questions. Any instability means a missed payment — the loss of everything. The state didn't keep you in a cage. You locked yourself in one and gave the key to the bank.*

— **The illusion of the middle class:** *We were made to feel that owning branded trainers made us part of the "elite." We became residents who are proud of their expensive curtains while the pipes quietly rot in the basement. Visual success became the replacement for meaning.*

Analytical conclusion: This period was the most dangerous in our history — precisely because it looked like the safest. We voluntarily atrophied our social instincts in exchange for comfort. We allowed Management Companies to become enormous bureaucratic machines that simulate care through inflation graphs. We thought history had ended. In reality, it had simply gone quiet in the basement while we were choosing bathroom tiles.

Transition mechanism: *Atomisation created a demand for the illusion of connection. People were left alone — and the internet offered them "community." Problem seemingly solved. In reality the problem doubled: the new "communities" worked not on unity but on ignition. Why — see the next chapter.*

1.3. The Digital Cocoon: Loneliness in a Crowd (2010–2020)

If the '90s gave us the microwave, the decade from 2010 to 2020 gave us something more intimate — a screen as an extension of the retina. This was the era when the Management Companies realised: to stop residents from rioting about the leaking roof, you just need to give each of them a personal television for their pocket and noise-cancelling headphones.

"Societies have always been shaped more by the nature of the media by which men communicate than by the content of the communication." — Marshall McLuhan, The Gutenberg Galaxy (1962)

McLuhan wrote this fifty years before Facebook appeared — and proved prophetically accurate. The algorithms of Facebook, Twitter, and YouTube were not neutral tools for connection. They were machines built to maximise "engagement" — the time a user spends on the platform. And the engineers of these companies very quickly discovered: anger holds attention better than joy. Fear and hatred — better than love and calm.

| **Berlin, 2018.**

Sara Hauer, Werner's granddaughter, 23, content manager. She has 2,847 Instagram followers, of whom she has personally met eleven. She unlocks her phone an average of 150 times a day. This is not using a device — it's a nervous tic. When Uncle Peter writes something "wrong" in the family chat about refugee policy, Sara blocks him. "I simply cannot tolerate toxic people," she explains to her friend Lea. Lea nods: she had the same issue with a distant cousin.

Sara didn't vote in last year's election: "There's nobody decent to vote for." When grandfather Werner heard this, he was silent for five seconds. Then he said only: "People died for that right." Sara sent him a heart emoji and closed the chat.

1. Algorithmic Bubbles: The Death of Shared Reality

In the Cold War era, a German and an American, a Russian and a Pole — had different governments, different ideologies, but the same facts. The Soviet Union existed. The Berlin Wall existed. The threat of nuclear war existed. You could argue about interpretations — but not about facts.

By 2020, even that shared factual layer had vanished from developed democracies. Algorithms built personal information bubbles in which the same person could see diametrically opposed "facts" — depending on whom they follow. Debate became impossible not because people are bad, but because they literally lived in different informational worlds.

— **The illusion of connection:** *We seemed to grow closer (social media, messengers), but in reality we had simply locked ourselves into "digital cocoons." The residents of the "Global ERC" stopped saying hello in the elevator — each was busy reading news about what idiots live in the next block.*

— **The death of discourse:** *We lost the ability to talk to those who think differently. "Just don't read them" — this principle, elevated into an axiom, killed political culture more effectively than any censorship.*

2. Divide and Rule 2.0: A Political Gift

— **Anger management:** *There was no longer any need to unite people around a great goal. It was enough to divide them over petty issues: skin colour, diet, word choices,*

sexual identity, musical taste. Each such division created new "us" and new "them" — without any missiles.

— **Hatred for a comment:** *We began to hate each other not over resources or territory, but over text on a screen. While we busily "cancelled" each other on Twitter, city managers quietly redistributed budgets, built surveillance systems, and moved money offshore. The perfect distraction.*

3. The Dopamine Conveyor: How People Were Turned into Lab Rats

If religion was once the opium of the masses, in the 2010s it was replaced by an endless dopamine cycle. Likes, comments, notifications, retweets — each one activated the same brain reward system as gambling. Silicon Valley accidentally (and then deliberately) created the most effective addiction machine in history.

— **Atomisation:** *Eight billion loners in headphones. We became ideal consumers — predictable, manageable, and utterly incapable of collective action. What can you do when you have no one to organise with?*

— **The loss of the weight of reality:** *Real-world events began to feel like a Netflix series. Real blood, real hunger, and real corruption became "content" you could swipe away if it ruined your mood. The algorithm taught us that the world is what we want to see. It was a lie we fell in love with.*

Analytical conclusion: The digital cocoon became the perfect straitjacket of a new kind. Soft, bright, and very comfortable. We voluntarily handed the keys to our attention to algorithms — meaning to whoever controls those algorithms. By 2020, humanity approached a state of maximum fragmentation under a maximum illusion of connection. When the real crises came knocking, it turned out: behind our beautiful profiles there was nothing but emptiness and confusion.

Transition mechanism: *The digital cocoon made the rot of institutions invisible — right up to the moment it became impossible to ignore. The pandemic of 2020 turned the lights on in the operating theatre. And everyone saw that the surgeons were drunk.*

1.4. The Great Collapse of Simulacra: When the Scenery Fell (2020–2026)

"Fragile systems do not break from obvious threats, but from accumulated vulnerabilities that no one ever bothered to fix." — Nassim Taleb, Antifragile

We have arrived at the moment of truth. If the preceding decades were a long party on credit, then the period from 2020 to 2026 was the morning when the lights came on — and it turned out we were in an operating theatre where the surgeons are drunk, the instruments are made of plasticine, and the patient has been dead for some time, but no one wants to record the fact.

| **Berlin, 2023. 2:14 a.m.**

Sara Hauer stares at the ceiling. The electricity bill for last month rose by another 40%. Her mother sent an article: "How to Save €300 a Month on Groceries." Sara's job still exists, but her real salary after inflation has effectively fallen by 12%. Grandfather Werner stood at the blast furnace his whole life, received a pension, and knew what tomorrow held. She got three degrees — and doesn't know what will happen in three months.

At three in the morning she opens the banking app. The balance is such that the next rent payment will sting. Sara closes the app. Opens Instagram. There — the beautiful lives of one hundred and seven people. Closes Instagram. Stares at the ceiling. Thinks: "Something is wrong here. Something is fundamentally wrong."

1. The Competence Test: The Adults Aren't Home

The pandemic of 2020 became the first large-scale system failure — and the first public competency test for states. It was the moment when residents of the "Global ERC" grasped a terrifying fact: international institutions (WHO, UN, WTO) are not a world government. They are an HR department that knows only how to write reports.

— **Paper tigers:** *While people hunted for masks and hand sanitiser, the Management Companies were busy passing the blame. We saw that in a real crisis, global alliances collapse within 24 hours. Every man for himself. "Solidarity" is just a word for press releases.*

— **KPIs vs. lives:** *Instead of real solutions, we got statistical games. Politicians fought not the disease, but the fall in their own approval ratings. The difference in approach proved noticeable. Countries with functioning state institutions recovered quickly. Countries with beautiful political slogans — did not.*

2. The Collapse of Military Mythology: A \$500 Drone

The local wars of this period definitively destroyed the myth of "sacred duty" and "heroic defence." It turned out that an aircraft carrier costing \$13 billion and a tank worth \$4.5 million can be destroyed by a home-built contraption of plywood and duct tape with a grenade attached. More on what this means for the state's monopoly on violence — in the next chapter. For now, it's enough to record the fact: the pomp died. And with it, slowly, died the willingness to pay for war through taxes.

3. The Economics of Rage and Scarcity

— **Inflation as a tax on life:** *While politicians printed trillions to douse the fires they themselves lit, real resources (energy, food, housing) began rising exponentially. The middle class discovered that its savings were evaporating faster than salaries were growing.*

— **The end of the liberal fairytale:** *Freedom of speech and democracy mean nothing if the heating doesn't work and the rubbish hasn't been collected in months. The Management Companies stopped delivering the basic service but kept demanding loyalty. Residents began asking the uncomfortable question: exactly what are we paying for?*

Analytical conclusion: By 2026, the simulacra had definitively crumbled. We saw the unappealing reality behind every façade — Western and Eastern alike. Corruption, cronyism, and total incompetence became obvious even to those who never left their digital cocoon. The old governance system cannot be repaired — it simply was not designed for life. It was designed to sustain itself. But the collapse of a system is not the finale. It is a question: what comes next?

Chapter 2. Theatrical Scenery: How NATO and the EU Became "Paper Tigers"

Chapter 1 described how society atrophied. Now let's look at how its main institutions atrophied — not accidentally and not suddenly, but according to the same logic: without a real functional purpose, a tool begins serving itself.

Imagine a residents' committee that meets every month, drinks coffee, takes minutes, and passes resolutions about the need to fix the pipes in the basement. For twenty-five years. The pipes meanwhile keep getting worse. The minutes, however, keep getting longer.

That is roughly what NATO and the European Union looked like by 2026. These organisations were built for a specific threat — a Soviet armoured column advancing through the Fulda Gap. The threat vanished in 1991. The organisations remained. And at that point they underwent what all institutions undergo after outliving their reason for existence: they stopped working and started simply existing.

2.1. NATO: An Alliance Without an Adversary and Thirty-Two Vetoes

NATO's original logic was elegant to the point of brutality. The alliance's first Secretary General, Lord Ismay, summed it up as: "keep the Russians out, the Americans in, and the Germans down." Three tasks. Clear. Measurable. It worked.

By 2026, none of those tasks existed in their original form. What did the alliance do? It invented new tasks.

NATO successively became "vital" for fighting terrorism: Afghanistan — 20 years, \$2.3 trillion in combined coalition spending, result — the Taliban in power from the very first day of withdrawal. For "crisis management": Libya, 2011 — the country became a failed state with slave markets. For "cyber defence": without a single coordinated response to any major state-level attack.

Each expansion of the mandate concealed the same truth: no one could clearly explain why NATO was needed. When someone asks you that and you have no answer — you start looking for a new reason to exist. That is how institutional zombies are born.

The Consensus Principle with 32 Members

In an alliance where every country has a veto, real decisions are made only in two cases: when the threat is so obvious that argument is impossible — or when the US has already decided and invited the others to "support." Everything else is 32 months of negotiating what to put in the press release.

Smaller alliance members spent 1.2–1.5% of GDP on defence instead of the obligatory 2% — and continued to enjoy the American security umbrella for free. This is called "the free rider problem" at civilisational scale. Residents who don't pay the service charge but use the concierge.

By 2026, NATO housed 27 different command-and-control systems. Aircraft from different member nations could not exchange tactical data in real time. Armoured vehicles operated on incompatible frequencies. Ammunition was not interchangeable. This was not a military alliance — it was a coalition of national armies that occasionally run joint exercises. At the first real crisis, everyone would pull in their own direction — and slowly.

2.2. The EU: Bureaucracy as an End in Itself

By 2026, the European Union was a remarkable phenomenon: a supranational structure with an annual budget of \$185 billion, 50,000 officials in Brussels alone — and a zero capacity for rapid response. The EU could take any decision — exactly at the point when it no longer mattered.

170,000 Pages of Legislation

EU law by 2026 ran to more than 170,000 pages. No single person could know all of it. No business could fully comply without a staff lawyer. The most eloquent example: the AI Act, adopted in 2024 — the world's first comprehensive regulatory document in this area. While American and Chinese companies rolled out new AI models in weeks, European startups were studying 150-page requirements for documenting "high-risk" systems. While competitors were building, the EU was creating committees to oversee the building.

The Energy Failure: 27 National Policies Instead of One

The most painful test was energy. In 2022, when Russian gas supplies ceased, it emerged that the EU had no unified energy policy — just 27 national policies, regularly in conflict with each other. Germany built Nord Stream 2 despite the objections of Poland and the Baltic states. Hungary maintained Gazprom contracts in violation of the sanctions' spirit. Every country quietly made its own arrangements.

Result: electricity prices in the peak period of 2022 rose 280% against 2021 levels. By 2026 they remained 70–90% above pre-pandemic levels. European industry — chemicals, metals, glass — methodically relocated production to the US, India, and China. Deindustrialisation happened not with a bang but with a quiet exodus. The apartment was slowly emptying.

2.3. Why They Didn't Die

Here an uncomfortable question is necessary: if NATO and the EU were functioning so poorly — why didn't they fall apart?

Because it was in no participant's interest to be the first to press the dissolution button.

NATO survived because small countries got free security and the US maintained political influence in Europe at a cost below the alternatives. The EU survived because the single market genuinely worked and genuinely enriched all participants — despite all the bureaucracy. No one wanted to lose access to a market of 450 million consumers.

Institutional zombies are not a conspiracy. They are the rational behaviour of participants, each of whom prefers an imperfect status quo to the unknown consequences of change. The problem is that zombies consume resources — political, financial, intellectual. While Europe's best minds were writing regulatory requirements for start-ups, Silicon Valley and Shenzhen were creating the future.

Analytical conclusion: By 2026, NATO and the EU were something more dangerous than fiction: systems that consumed enormous resources with minimal output and created the illusion of governance where there was none. A resident who has paid for an elevator repair but still walks eight flights of stairs understands this intuitively. By 2026, there were critically many such residents.

Analytical transition: *So the institutions have rotted. But while they were rotting — something important happened in another domain: the state's monopoly on violence quietly disappeared. A \$500 drone killed not only expensive hardware — it killed the very concept of military superiority as guarantor of political power. That is the theme of the next chapter.*

Chapter 3. A \$500 Drone: The Democratisation of Killing and the End of the Military Monopoly

In October 2022, Ukrainian forces destroyed a Russian T-90M tank worth \$4.5 million. They destroyed it with a DJI Mavic quadcopter, bought in an electronics shop for \$1,500, with a Soviet anti-tank grenade PG-7 attached — cost \$30.

The cost-to-target ratio: one to three thousand.

This was not a technical curiosity. It was a historical watershed that politicians initially refused to acknowledge, while military strategists acknowledged it — and quietly set about rethinking everything they knew about war. And about power.

3.1. The Equaliser: How \$500 Neutralises \$13 Billion

The USS Gerald R. Ford cost American taxpayers \$13.3 billion. It carries 75 aircraft and 4,500 crew. It was built as a symbol of absolute superiority — a floating argument in any diplomatic conversation.

In 2023, Yemeni Houthis began attacking ships in the Red Sea with kamikaze drones costing \$10,000–50,000 each. The cost of the SM-2 interceptor missile used by American destroyers to destroy them: \$2.1 million.

The arithmetic is catastrophic: the Houthis — an organisation with no state budget, no aviation, no navy — blockaded the Red Sea and forced one of the world's largest naval powers to spend millions destroying drones worth tens of thousands. Container shipping costs from Asia to Europe rose threefold to fourfold. Insurance companies raised premiums for ships in the region by 300%. Global trade was rerouting.

Three US carrier strike groups were in the region — and the Red Sea was blockaded anyway. This was not a military failure — it was a conceptual failure. Expensive military potential ceases to be a deterrent when the adversary has no fear of losing anything and nothing that can be destroyed in return.

3.2. The Garage Revolution: Who Can Now Wage War

Before the drone era, there was a natural barrier to entry into the "military players' club." An army required heavy industry, aviation factories, a fleet, logistical infrastructure spanning hundreds of kilometres. All of this took decades to build and decades to fund. A small country or non-state actor simply could not afford a war with a large state — the gap in industrial capacity was insurmountable.

By 2026, that barrier no longer existed.

An FPV drone is a carbon frame, four electric motors, a racing flight controller, a camera, and a smartphone as the operator's monitor. With a combat payload — a grenade or shaped charge — cost \$300–600. Range: up to 10 kilometres. Speed: up to 150 km/h. The operator could be a 20-year-old with experience flying racing quadcopters — a hobby accessible to anyone. In 2025, Ukraine produced more than 1.5 million combat drones — without giant factories, without special steel, without complex logistics.

The next level: swarm attacks. Against a simultaneous swarm of 100 drones, classical anti-aircraft artillery is helpless: insufficient rate of fire. Anti-aircraft missiles are too expensive. Laser systems are the only adequate response, but their production was only just beginning. States that spent decades creating "impenetrable" shields discovered that the shield has a hole the size of a DJI Mavic.

3.3. Nuclear Blackmail: Why the Button No Longer Frightens as It Once Did

The Cold War rested on a simple formula: attacking a nuclear power means mutual destruction. Fear is symmetrical — no one attacks. The drone broke that symmetry.

If a non-state actor attacks a nuclear power with a swarm of drones — what does the nuclear power do in response? Deploy tactical nuclear weapons against a target that a single conventional missile could destroy? Threaten an adversary that has no cities to take hostage? Nuclear weapons are an instrument of pressure on a state whose population fears death and has something to lose. They are almost useless against a decentralised threat that has no capital to destroy and no leader to threaten.

By 2026, this had become not theory but operational reality. The Button continued to exist — but it no longer frightened quite as convincingly as before. And that meant the principal argument that justified the state's existence as the monopolist of violence was vanishing.

3.4. The Death of Heroism and the Birth of Video Content

There is an aspect that is not usually discussed in official military doctrine.

War traditionally required human sacrifice — not only physical but psychological. A soldier went into the attack knowing he might die. This created space for meaning: "I died for my country." For heroism. For state propaganda. The entire state narrative of "sacred duty" rested on the idea that death for the flag is not just death — it is something greater.

An FPV drone operator sits in a basement, in warmth, in front of two monitors. He sees the thermal signature of the target. Presses a button. A few seconds later the target stops being a signature. The operator opens a new tab.

This does not make the war any less lethal for those on the other side of the screen. But it completely destroys its psychological architecture. Video footage from FPV cameras flooded the internet — and turned war into content. Terrible, repellent, watched by millions. The pomp died first. Behind it, slowly, died the willingness to pay for war through taxes. And that willingness is precisely the thread by which the state hangs.

Analytical conclusion: A \$500 drone is not a technical novelty. It is a first-order political event. It proved that the state's monopoly on violence — held since the Peace of Westphalia in 1648 — is broken. And that monopoly is the foundation of the social contract. You pay taxes because the state protects you from those who are stronger. If it can no longer guarantee that — why pay? This question was not asked out loud. But it was asked silently — every time someone watched the Houthis blockade the Red Sea.

Analytical transition: *Institutional authority is broken (Chapter 2). Military authority is broken (Chapter 3). One thing remains — economic authority. If the state can't protect you from military threat and can't make the institutions work, it should at least ensure your money doesn't turn into paper. By 2026, it had failed at that too.*

Chapter 4. The Economics of Rage: Inflation as Political Verdict

There is an exact moment when a person stops trusting the state. Not when they are arrested for the wrong words. Not when they read a corruption exposé. It happens in the supermarket.

They pick up a product they have bought their whole life, look at the price tag — and feel something between insult and betrayal. In that moment, the silent contract — "we provide stability, you provide loyalty" — develops a crack. Not a break — precisely a crack. The break comes later. When enough such moments have accumulated.

By 2026, billions of people had accumulated more than enough.

4.1. The Great Printing Press

Between 2020 and 2023, the governments of developed economies pumped unprecedented stimulus into their economies. The US injected \$5.3 trillion — direct cheques, subsidised loans, business support. The EU launched NextGenerationEU for €800 billion. Central banks held rates near zero and collectively expanded their balance sheets by more than \$9 trillion.

This was a logical anti-crisis response — the alternative was a depression on the scale of the 1930s. The problem was that the money was printed, but no goods were produced to go with it. When demand recovered in 2021–2022, it emerged that supply chains had collapsed, labour was scarce, and there was an excess of cash in people's hands.

Inflation in the euro zone reached 10.6% in October 2022 — a record for the entire history of the single currency. In the US the peak was 9.1% in June 2022 — the highest since 1981. In the UK — 11.1%. For political economy these were not statistics. They were thermometers measuring the temperature of social trust. And they showed — fever.

4.2. The Arithmetic of Rage: Three People, Three Countries

Abstract percentages become very concrete decisions. Here are three.

Sarah Collins, schoolteacher. Manchester, 2023.

Salary £32,000 a year. Nominal pay rise in 2022–2023: 3%. Real purchasing power over two years: minus 15%. Simple arithmetic: she became poorer by roughly three monthly salaries, while formally working the same job and being paid more. In 2023, 6.5 million British households were in "energy poverty" — forced to choose between heating and eating. Sarah was not among them, but she knew people who were. And she understood clearly that one serious breakdown at home, and she would be too.

In the local elections, Sarah voted against the incumbent government. Not because she knew what she wanted. Because she knew what she no longer wanted.

Mariusz Kowalski, truck driver. Łódź, 2023.

He had voted for "stability" his whole conscious life. Considered himself a practical man, not into politics. Drove lorries across Europe, saving up for a car for his son. Polish inflation in 2022–2023 reached 18%. In eighteen months his savings — what he had been putting aside for eight years — lost roughly half their value.

Mariusz was not angry at his neighbour. Not angry at migrants. Not angry at "globalisation." He was angry specifically — at the system that had allowed prices to rise to the point where politicians' words about "temporary difficulties" sounded like mockery. This was not ideological rage. This was bookkeeping rage. The arithmetic of betrayal.

Diego Fernández, restaurant owner. Buenos Aires, 2023.

Inflation in Argentina exceeded 211%. Diego stopped accepting cash — it lost value faster than he could spend it. The restaurant menu was updated twice a day: morning prices and evening prices. The evening meal was 8–12% more expensive than the morning. Suppliers demanded payment in cryptocurrency or dollars at the unofficial rate. Diego worked 14 hours a day and was falling behind.

By 2025–2026, signs of "Argentinisation" — the loss of trust in the national currency and state institutions — were being recorded by analysts in Turkey, Pakistan, Nigeria, and Egypt: countries with a combined population of over a billion people. Argentina had stopped being an exotic exception. Argentina had become a warning.

4.3. Rage Takes to the Streets

"Evils which are patiently endured when they seem inevitable become intolerable when once the idea of escape from them is suggested." — Alexis de Tocqueville, The Old Regime and the Revolution

Sociologists have long known: poverty is a poor predictor of revolutions. A starving person is busy surviving — no time for barricades. Revolutions are made by those who got "a little worse" after a period of getting "a little better." That is exactly what was happening.

Sri Lanka, 2022.

The country declared its first-ever default. Three-hour queues for products. Fuel shortages. Inflation approaching 70%. Protesters broke into the presidential palace and swam in the presidential pool. President Gotabaya Rajapaksa fled by military aircraft — first to the Maldives, then Singapore, then Thailand. No country wanted to accept him. In the end he returned and resigned from abroad. All of this — because the state could not provide people with food and fuel. Not over ideology. Over logistics.

Bangladesh, 2024.

Student protests against a quota system for government employment grew into a mass movement. Behind the quotas lay accumulated resentment: years of living, studying, earning degrees — only to discover that good jobs went to those who knew the right people, not those who studied hardest. Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, who had ruled the country for 15 years, fled by helicopter to India. Fifteen years of power — gone in a matter of weeks. The trigger: unemployment among educated young people: those with degrees, with nowhere to go.

France, 2018–2022.

The Gilets Jaunes started with a fuel tax rise — formally insignificant. But the tax resonated with an accumulated feeling: the state serves urban elites, ignoring those who live in the provinces and drive to work. The movement lasted more than a year. The government reversed the initial measure — but the rage went nowhere. It simply reformatted itself into deep distrust of all institutions at once.

The common denominator of all these events is not ideology. The demands were laughably utilitarian: that public transport should work properly, that the cost of living should

match wages, that corruption should not eat what taxes have paid for. That is the economics of rage. Not ideological anger — operational anger. The anger of a resident whose management company hasn't fixed the lift, but has sent a bill with a higher tariff.

4.4. Liberal Democracy: Death by Incompetence

Liberal democracy had an answer to every political crisis: elections. If the government manages badly — vote for another one. The system self-corrects.

By 2026, it emerged that this logic works on one condition: the existence of meaningfully different alternatives. In most developed democracies there were none. "Left" and "right" offered marginally different versions of the same policy. Both sides consisted of professional politicians whose career logic required re-election, not the resolution of problems that threatened re-election.

The result was politics of "tomorrow's problems." The pension crisis — politically too expensive to fix now. The climate crisis — too long-term for an electoral cycle. The infrastructure debt — better to borrow and pass it on to the next generation. By 2026, the combined debt of G7 countries exceeded \$65 trillion. It was debt that no one planned to repay. Not one political party offered a programme under which this would be mathematically possible without a catastrophic fall in living standards.

As Charles de Talleyrand observed two centuries ago: "You can do much with bayonets, but you cannot sit on them." By 2026, politicians discovered that their bayonets had dulled, their debt obligations were mounting, and residents were no longer listening to speeches about greatness.

Analytical conclusion: By 2026, liberal democracy had not been killed by dictators or ideological rivals. It was suffocating under the weight of its own promises, which the economy could no longer keep. A resident whose management company has been promising renovation for years doesn't stage a revolution — he files a cancellation of services. Or asks himself: why do I need a management company at all, if I can hire a decent plumber directly? That question was one of the most important questions of 2026. And it was what led to everything that came next.

WHY EXACTLY THE TRIAD? THE MECHANISM OF TRANSITION FROM CHAOS TO ORDER

A brief explanation of why the world did not fall apart — but regrouped.

After four chapters of destruction, the reader has a legitimate question: if everything is so bad — why didn't chaos break out? Why did two hundred new states not appear, thirty new dictators, or one world war?

The answer is simple, though uncomfortable: because chaos has competitors. And in 2026, three of them were strong enough to fill the vacuum.

Three Functions, Three Players

When an old order collapses, a new order forms not on an ideological principle — "whose idea won" — but on a functional one: who can actually provide what people need here and now.

In 2026, humanity needed three things:

— **Security:** *who will stop those who want to destroy everything? Who holds the deterrence monopoly? Who still has enough military technology that their threat sounds credible?*

— **Production:** *who will make things? Who will build ports, lay cables, assemble batteries? Who has the industrial scale to serve eight billion people?*

— **Resources:** *who will supply energy and food? Without oil, gas, uranium, and wheat, even the smartest military and industrial machine stops.*

These three functions had historically become concentrated in three players.

The US controlled military technology, financial infrastructure (the dollar, SWIFT), and the "meaning machine" — media, universities, technology platforms. They produced ideas, interfaces, and money flows.

China controlled production. 78% of the world's lithium-ion batteries. 90% of rare-earth refining. Over a hundred strategic ports across sixty countries. Without Chinese factories, the West's "green transition" turned into a pumpkin, and its "smart cities" into beautiful concepts without hardware.

Russia controlled physical resources and the weapon of last resort. 70% of global export of nuclear power plant construction technology. 25% of global wheat exports. The largest supplier of fertilisers. The most powerful electronic warfare system. And, of course, a nuclear arsenal — which, for all the criticism, still functions as the final argument.

Not a Conspiracy — Gravity

It is important to understand: the Triad did not emerge from a secret conspiracy and not from an international treaty. No one sat at a table and divided the planet. The world simply organised itself around three centres of competence — just as water flows to the lowest points in the landscape. Physics, not politics.

None of the three players could eliminate the other two without collapsing themselves. The US depends on Chinese manufacturing and Russian nuclear technology. China depends on American financial markets and Russian raw materials. Russia depends on the American technology sector and Chinese consumers. This is not an alliance — it is a mutual lock.

When the Management Companies (the old states) finally lost residents' trust, these three players offered alternative service packages. They were imperfect. They were contradictory. But they worked — unlike what had preceded them.

Conclusion: The shift from "chaos" to "the Triad" was not a choice — it was an inevitability. When old governance structures collapse, the world does not descend into uniform chaos. It organises itself around what genuinely works. In 2026, these three centres genuinely worked. How well — that is a different question. It is the theme of the next section.

PART II THE TRIAD ERA: A WORLD OF THREE CONTRACTORS

The last stop before the abolition of politics.

This period will go down in history as "the Great Outsourcing." Humanity, exhausted by the endless choice between "bad" and "very bad," decided to delegate governance to three global operating systems.

Chapter 5. The US (The Brand): The World as Digital Façade

If you want to live in a beautiful picture where every breakfast is a manifesto of freedom and your life is an endless Netflix series, you choose the American contract.

— **The product:** *Ideas, meanings, interfaces, and financial magic.*

— **The essence:** *By 2026, the US had definitively stopped being "the world's policeman" and had become "the World's Creative Director." They own the software running your brain and the currency backed only by your faith in a bright future.*

— **The trap:** *In this building's wing, everything is painted very beautifully — but the marketing bills are ten times the cost of the apartment itself.*

5.1. The Transactional Model: Security as a Service

The US National Defence Strategy, published in January 2026, formally enshrined the shift to a "homeland-first" and transactional approach. The US no longer protects allies "just because." In return, it requires either direct financial contributions or economic concessions.

5.2. The Case of South Korea and Japan: "Investment Tribute"

— **South Korea (May 2025):** *A 2026–2030 agreement was signed. In 2026 Seoul pays 1.5192 trillion won (around \$1.1 billion).*

— **Japan (February 2026):** *Tokyo committed to investing \$550 billion in US sectors critical to national security, including energy and reindustrialisation.*

5.3. Resource Deals: Security-for-Minerals

— **DRC (Congo):** *In exchange for military support against M23 rebels, the government granted the US priority access to copper mines.*

— **Ukraine (April 2025):** *A Reconstruction Investment Fund agreement was signed. The US gains preferences in titanium and rare-earth metal extraction in exchange for continued military supplies.*

5.4. The Defence Industry: The "Golden Dome" as Premium Product

In fiscal year 2025, total US weapons sales hit a record \$331 billion. "The Golden Dome" — a new global missile defence concept — turned security into a premium commodity that only loyal clients can afford.

Analytical conclusion: The US in 2026 is not an "Empire" — it is a security franchise. They don't want to run your cities; they want to own your markets and resources in exchange for ensuring your cities are not destroyed.

Chapter 6. China (The Factory): The World as Conveyor Belt and Resource Base

By 2026, China had definitively stopped being "the world's cheap factory" and had become the Global Operating System of the material world. If the US sells protection, China sells the very fact that your morning begins with a working kettle, a charged phone, and functioning public transport.

6.1. The Monopoly on "Hardware"

By 2026, China's share of global lithium-ion battery production had reached 78%. Without Chinese factories (CATL, BYD), the West's "green transition" turns into a pumpkin.

This is not just business — it is infrastructural leverage. Beijing no longer imposes communism; it imposes its own charging standards, its chips, its communication protocols.

6.2. BRI 2.0: Logistics OS

The Belt and Road Initiative had by 2026 mutated into a Digital Silk Road. Under direct or indirect management of Chinese state corporations sit over 100 strategic ports in 60 countries worldwide.

China launched LOGINK — a unified cargo monitoring platform. Beijing can see every movement of goods across the planet in real time.

6.3. Resource Sovereignty

China accounts for 90% of global rare-earth refining. In 2025 China introduced export quotas on graphite and gallium. Result? Prices on Western radars and batteries jumped 40% in a single quarter.

Analytical conclusion: China in 2026 is the Main Contractor for life support. Their strategy: "quiet acquisition" through dependencies. They arrive with a contract to build

a port and 5G infrastructure. And five years later it turns out the key to your city gates is in the pocket of a city manager from Shenzhen.

Chapter 7. Russia (The Shield & The Engine): The Survival Range and the Global Boiler Room

By 2026, Russia had definitively accepted the role that other players were afraid to take on — the role of Chief Engineer for life support under extreme conditions. If the US is a gleaming facade and security, and China is an endless conveyor of goods, then Russia is the gruff mechanic in a greasy overalls who knows how to start the generator when it's -40°C outside and communications are down.

7.1. The Energy Safe and the "Nuclear Battery"

By early 2026, Russia controls more than 70% of global exports of nuclear power plant construction technology. Small Modular Reactors (SMR) have become the primary export commodity for countries that don't want to depend on the whims of weather or sanctions.

Russia has become "the global power socket." If China makes the kettles, Russia makes sure there is always current in the socket.

7.2. The Shield: Asymmetry and "Access Denial"

Russian military doctrine by 2026 had definitively mutated from "offensive" to "barrier." Russia became the monopolist in EW (electronic warfare) technologies. While the US spends billions on one aircraft, Russia produces systems that shoot that aircraft down with a \$50,000 missile.

7.3. Food Sovereignty: "Wheat OPEC"

In 2025 Russia accounted for 25% of global wheat exports and became the largest fertiliser supplier. Beijing and Washington may argue about chips, but both come to Moscow for grain and potassium.

7.4. The Northern Sea Route: The Global Freight Lift

By 2026, melting ice and the most powerful icebreaker fleet in the world (including the "Leader" class) had turned the NSR into a major planetary artery. This is the shortest route from "the Factory" (China) to "the Consumer" (Europe). Russia here is not just a carrier but the owner of the corridor.

Analytical conclusion: The Triad's logic: the US is "Brains and Software," China is "Hands and Iron," Russia is "Spine and Fuel." None of these players can remove either of the others without bringing the whole house down. The US fears running out of Chinese goods and Russian uranium; China fears losing American markets; Russia knows it holds the keys to the boiler room and waits for the other residents to fully realise that.

Chapter 8. The Loyalty Market: Why Countries Choose Their "Roof" by Business Plan, Not History Textbook

"Alliance partners are states with temporarily coinciding interests, not families sharing a common fate." — Henry Kissinger

This cynical formula became official doctrine by 2026. Affiliation with a "roof" ceased to be a question of ideology, historical tradition, or "Western values." It became a purely business decision. Small and medium-sized states analysed the Triad's offers like corporate tenders — attentively, coolly, without sentiment.

8.1. Three Service Packages

Each Triad player offered a fundamentally different product. No one imposed — they offered. The market was a buyer's market.

Criterion	US (The Brand)	China (The Factory)	Russia (The Engine)
Main product	Security + ideas	Infrastructure + manufacturing	Energy + resources + shield
Entry conditions	Open markets, "values"	Debt obligations, logistics	Political loyalty
Response speed	Slow (democratic procedures)	Fast (state corporations)	Very fast (resource swap)
Hidden cost	Loss of economic sovereignty	Technological dependency	Constrained foreign policy
Best suited for	Countries with developed economies	Emerging markets	Resource-exporting states

8.2. Three Case Studies: How It Looked in Practice

Saudi Arabia — the champion of balancing.

Riyadh by 2026 had become the world record holder for the number of simultaneous "roofs." American weapons (\$130 billion in FMS contracts over the preceding decade) and security guarantees. Chinese investment in oil refining and 5G infrastructure (\$55 billion in BRI agreements). Russian coordination within OPEC+, keeping oil prices up. And its own Vision 2030 programme — an attempt to wean itself off oil while using all three simultaneously.

The US Secretary of State expressed "concern" several times about Riyadh's relations with Beijing and Moscow. The Saudis politely noted the concern and continued doing what they were doing. This was a new kind of diplomacy: not monogamous marriage with one superpower, but an open polyamorous contract with three, each of whom knows the others exist.

Turkey — NATO member, buyer of Russian missiles.

Ankara purchased the Russian S-400 air defence system, formally violating NATO compatibility standards. The US imposed CAATSA sanctions. Turkey did not capitulate. The reason: Bayraktars — Turkey's own drones — had proven effective in Syria, Libya, and Nagorno-Karabakh. Turkey became one of the world's largest exporters of military drones, dependent on no Triad player. Erdoğan skilfully used geography — Turkey controls the Black Sea Straits; without it, NATO is helpless in the Black Sea. Perfect leverage: indispensable to all, belonging to none.

India — strategic autonomy as principle.

New Delhi by 2026 had formalised "strategic autonomy" as the official foreign policy doctrine. American technology investment (Apple relocated part of its production to India), Indian-American military cooperation in the Indo-Pacific region. Russian weapons (India is historically the largest buyer of Russian arms) and oil at a 30–40% discount (purchased circumventing Western sanctions). Chinese goods (despite border conflicts, trade turnover with China exceeded \$120 billion a year). India never once voted for resolutions against Russia at the UN — and never joined an anti-China bloc. Simply: buy from everyone, sell to everyone, fight only for ourselves.

8.3. The Honest Formula of Loyalty

By 2026, most countries of the world were not choosing — they were balancing between all three players, seeking to maximise the benefits received while minimising commitments. This "neutral" choice turned out to be the most pragmatic diplomatic move in history.

This was not a betrayal of Western values. This was growing up. Old-school politicians called it "authoritarianism" and a "non-liberal turn." Practitioners called it "common sense under uncertainty."

When an American congressman demanded that the Indian prime minister "choose a side," he politely replied: "India's side is India." And it was precisely this answer — spoken in different languages in Ankara, Riyadh, Bangalore, Lagos, and Jakarta — that became the anthem of the Triad era.

Analytical conclusion: The Loyalty Market became an honest mirror of global politics. When ideology disappeared as a motivator — calculation and interest remained. This is not cynicism. This is maturity. Exactly what the Apostles of Common Sense were trying

to communicate to all humanity: efficiency over ideology, calculation over faith, pragmatics over pomp. The Loyalty Market was the first honest international market in history — because people bought what they actually needed, not what they were supposed to want.

THE GREAT BRAIN INVENTORY

Transition from geography to skills.

Chapter 9. Digital Nomad 2.0: The Death of the Passport and the Triumph of Skill

"I am a citizen of the world." — Diogenes of Sinope (per Diogenes Laertius, Lives of the Eminent Philosophers, VI.63)

If version 1.0 was about freelancers with laptops under palm trees, then Digital Nomad 2.0 is about the total detachment of qualified labour from territory. This was the moment when 8 billion residents realised: their passport is simply a forced subscription to the "services" of a state that works ever worse.

9.1. The Passport as "Tax on Origin"

By 2026 it had become definitively clear: the colour of your passport cover determines not your identity, but the size of the "commission" the local Management Company (government) charges you. Global corporations and major Triad hubs began implementing Skill-based ID — identification by skills. They stopped caring where you are registered.

9.2. The Global Competence Registry

In 2025 the largest tech companies (from SpaceX to Huawei) switched to hiring via blockchain attestation. Your real project experience is written into an immutable registry. You no longer need to lie on LinkedIn. Your skills are verified by your results.

9.3. Tax Deserter or Rational Resident?

By 2026, the phenomenon of "digital citizenship" had emerged. People began choosing their tax residence the way they choose a mobile phone plan. The US, China, and Russia were the first to understand that fighting this was pointless. Instead of chasing "refugees," they began competing for them.

Chapter 10. Removing the Splinters: How the Triad Quietly Stepped Back from Old Commitments

A "splinter" in ERC 'Earth' terminology is a local conflict or state whose ambitions are disproportionate to its contribution to global stability. By 2026, none of the "splinters" were "removed" militarily — the Triad simply stopped investing in their preservation the resources that previous generations of politicians had spent. This was not conspiracy. It was pragmatic distancing, masked as routine.

10.1. Israel: The Erosion of the "Special Relationship"

The war with Iran that began in February 2026 was the catalyst. By May the price of Brent crude had exceeded \$160, causing global logistics paralysis. For the US, traditional unconditional support for one regional player had become economically unviable.

Decisions that in previous decades had been taken automatically — weapons deliveries, diplomatic cover at the UN, military presence — now required justification, and the justification was increasingly hard to find. The US was not "surrendering" Israel unilaterally. They were gradually reducing the intensity of engagement, transferring some functions to regional players. Israel, for its part, was forced to move towards a broader regional diplomacy. By the end of the decade, the Middle East's architecture had changed — not through war, but through the quiet withdrawal of one of its external guardians.

10.2. Ukraine: The Exhaustion of Support Resources

By May 2026, "the Ukraine project" was recognised in Triad political circles as excessively costly. The US reduced military aid to symbolic levels by the end of 2025 — not because of rhetorical shifts, but because of domestic budget arithmetic. EU electricity costs remained 70–90% above pre-pandemic levels. Europe physically had no financial resource left to maintain the previous level of support.

The conflict did not end — it shifted to a "frozen grey zone" mode: without an official peace, without an official war, without an active combat phase, but also without recognised borders. This was advantageous to no one — except the Triad itself, where each player gained concrete benefit from the freeze and none had incentives to thaw it.

10.3. Taiwan: A Quiet Architectural Revision

By May 2026, the US and Russia had reached a tacit understanding: they would not actively oppose the gradual economic integration of Taiwan with mainland China. This was not "handing over" the island — it was an acknowledgement of a reality in which 90% of the island's technological stack already depended on Chinese suppliers, and key personnel and part of the TSMC production lines had by then been relocated to Arizona and Texas.

Taiwan's strategic value to the US had diminished — not because they stopped valuing it, but because they had managed to remove the most valuable elements beyond the risk zone. Further protection of the shell had become a matter of prestige rather than interest.

Section conclusion: The disappearance of the "splinters" is neither the result of "defeat" nor of conspiracy. It is the natural consequence of each Triad player calculating and

finding that maintaining the old commitment costs more than quietly winding it down. The conflicts were not "resolved" — they were removed from the priority list. The planet's residents breathed a sigh of relief: the old flashpoints of potential world war had simply moved into the category of "regional operational tasks."

Chapter 11. The Taiga as Luxury: The Geography of Solitude as the Highest Good

In the twentieth century everyone fled to cities for comfort. By 2026, cities had become "digital ghettos." Statistics from 2024–2025 recorded a shocking trend: sales of keypad phones without internet access in the 20–35 age bracket rose 25–40%.

11.1. The Phenomenon of "Dumbphones": The Great Disconnection

The average ERC 'Earth' resident in 2024 unlocked their smartphone 150 times a day. This is not using a device — it is a nervous tic. According to Pinterest data from summer 2025, searches for "Digital Detox" rose 72%. The dumbphone became a "passport to freedom." A person with a Nokia in 2026 looks like an elite that can afford to be unreachable.

11.2. The "Back to Base" Migration

In the US and Europe, net migration to rural areas in 2024–2025 reached its highest level since 1997. In 2025, 14% of 20–30-year-olds said they intended to move to small communities within two years.

11.3. Prerequisites for Self-Regulating Communities

- **Economic filter:** *The cost of living in a Triad megacity became a "tax on air."*
- **Social glue:** *Loneliness online gave way to a hunger for "analogue trust." Communities are built on personal knowledge: you trust your neighbour because he helped you fix your tractor.*
- **Technological scepticism:** *Groups of zoomer-engineers began building local "Mesh networks" — internet operating only within the community.*

Analytical conclusion: "Taiga as Luxury" is not about birch trees. It is about the right to make mistakes — which in the digital world of 2026 has been completely eliminated. While the Triad builds an ideal digital façade, deep in forests and villages the "autonomous nervous system" of the planet is forming.

Looking ahead: *What in 2024–2026 was a spontaneous movement of loners with dumbphones will by 2037 become a legally recognised form of life — the Reservations. The*

architecture of ERC 'Earth' will preserve the right to go offline as one of the five pillars of the new world. More on this in Part VII.

ELEVEN YEARS (2026–2037): HOW THE WORLD MOVED TO THE TIPPING POINT

History rarely changes in a single moment. It changes gradually — and then suddenly.

Phase I. Financial Shift (2026–2029)

In March 2027, Austria went to market with five-year bonds. Investors, glutted with Western sovereign debt, demanded yields incompatible with the sustainability of the Austrian budget. Vienna was forced to withdraw the issue.

In 2028, the Bank of Japan was forced to allow ten-year bonds to trade freely. The yen depreciated 18% in three months. Markets didn't collapse — but they warned. Loudly.

Phase II. AI and the Labour Market (2028–2032)

In 2028, Goldman Sachs published an updated forecast: 300 million jobs in developed economies were susceptible to automation over a 10-year horizon. Mid-market law firms cut lawyer headcounts by 40–60%. Accounting functions in medium businesses were automated rapidly and almost invisibly — until entire professions disappeared.

It was precisely in 2029–2031 that the "digital nomad" statistics began to change in quality. People whose professions were literally ceasing to exist discovered that physical presence "at home" gave them no advantages — only obligations.

Phase III. The Grey World — War Without Victory (2030–2034)

Historians call the period from 2030 to 2034 "The Era of Small Wars." Taiwan was never "reunified" — Beijing calculated that a military operation costs more than it delivers. Ukraine remained a divided "grey zone" without official peace and without official war.

It was in this period that what would later be called "the Apostles' Movement" began to form — though in 2030–2032 it was not yet a movement. These were isolated voices: engineers, urban planners, economists, publicly asking a simple question: "What if we simply did the sums?"

In 2031, a team of economists from MIT, Tokyo University, and the National University of Singapore jointly published "The Cost of Sovereignty." The annual global cost of maintaining borders and customs administration: \$9.4 trillion. The report was downloaded 47 million times in its first three months.

Phase IV. Assembly from Below — Cities Take Power (2033–2037)

When the national government cannot deliver a working health system, the mayor of Amsterdam makes an agreement with the mayor of Copenhagen on mutual recognition of medical protocols. When the national pension system is cracking, the Seoul city council launches a municipal savings programme with a verified blockchain registry.

By 2034, there were around 200 bilateral agreements between cities that bypassed the national level.

In 2035, twelve of the world's largest agglomerations signed a "Declaration of Operational Sovereignty." Formally — a memorandum of understanding. In practice — the first direct statement that cities are taking on the functions that national governments cannot handle.

In early 2037, when the architecture of ERC 'Earth' had finally come together, its founders said: "We did not build this system. We named what already existed."

Analytical conclusion: The transition of 2026–2037 was not a revolution. A revolution is when the new destroys the old. Here, the old slowly decomposed on its own — while the new was growing through the cracks, without asking permission. The state did not die. It surrendered — quietly, almost imperceptibly, transferring function after function to whoever handled it better.

PART IV THE TIPPING POINT: APOSTLES OF COMMON SENSE

The moment when 8 billion people fired the politicians.

A Brief Guide: Seventeen Formulas, One Idea

From the next page to the end of the book, you will encounter seventeen mathematical formulas. They should not alarm you — all of them express a single simple idea, presented from seventeen different angles.

That idea is: everything that in the old world was declared in words, in ERC 'Earth' is calculated in numbers.

The old Management Company said: "We care about security." ERC 'Earth' calculates the Safety Score — and if it falls, the manager is automatically dismissed. The old state said: "We have democracy." ERC 'Earth' calculates Social Consensus — the weighted voice of people who actually understand the issue. The old bureaucracy said: "This is a complex matter requiring discussion." ERC 'Earth' calculates the Political Friction Coefficient — and if it exceeds ten, discussion is replaced by a decision.

All formulas share the same structure: the numerator is what we want to achieve (useful output, security, authenticity, peace). The denominator is what gets in the way (friction, illusions, ideological enmity, bureaucracy). The smaller the denominator — the greater the result for the same input.

The most important point: the Apostles did not "invent" these formulas. They describe what has always worked in engineering disciplines. Engine efficiency is calculated this way. Drug effectiveness is calculated this way. Bridge strength is calculated this way. The Apostles simply transferred engineering honesty to the sphere of governing people — where previously only rhetoric had reigned.

Chapter 12. The Efficiency Formula: The Mathematical Dismantling of Power

Until 2037, humanity lived under the illusion that governing the world was a matter of "will," "charisma," or "ideology." We elected those who spoke best, not those who calculated best. A group of independent analysts, later called the "Apostles of Common Sense," introduced the concept of Political Friction.

12.1. The Universal Efficiency Equation

At the heart of the new world order lies the Universal Efficiency Equation (UEE):

$$E = \frac{I}{P \times n}$$

Where:

E — (*Efficiency*) — the real yield of useful product: a road built, a patient healed, a satellite launched

I — (*Idea*) — the pure concept of a solution: the mathematically verified algorithm

P — (*Political Approval*) — the number of "stakeholders" unrelated to the technical solution: lobbyists, unions, religious leaders

n — (*Bureaucratic Resistance*) — the level of corruption, number of forms required, and intermediary commissions

12.2. The Analytics of Exponential Decline

The great tragedy of the old world was that politicians tried to increase efficiency (E) by increasing idea funding (I). But the formula proves: when the denominator ($P \times n$) is large, any increase in the numerator only inflates the corruption potential — not the result.

12.3. The "Bridge Construction" Case Study

Here is a concrete example the Apostles used in their public talks. It is called "the Stockholm Bridge" — though the same story played out in dozens of other cities.

The original task:

An engineering team of 12 designs a new bridge across a bay. Calculations: 4 months. Construction: 3 years. Budget: 2.8 billion kronor. Materials chosen. Technology proven. $E = I / (P \times n)$, where $P = 3$ (client, contractor, inspector), $n = 1.2$. Efficiency: 0.93. Excellent.

What actually happened:

The following were added to the project:

- Heritage preservation committee (new bridge may alter the view of an 18th-century embankment): +8 months of hearings
- Environment department (possible impact on fish migration): +7 months of assessment
- Construction workers' union (requirement for priority hiring of local specialists): +3 months of negotiations
- Opposition parties (project used in election campaign): +5 months of "additional hearings"
- Architecture firm of the deputy mayor's cousin (alternative design "for discussion"): +4 months
- Budget revision due to inflation (during the hearings): +9 months of documentation rework

Result: design phase — 4 years 4 months instead of 4 months. Construction — 7 years instead of 3 (three contractor changes, one bankruptcy, two scandals). Cost: 9.2 billion kronor instead of 2.8 billion. P rose from 3 to 15. E fell from 0.93 to 0.19.

The bridge was built. It stands. But the cost of "political friction" was 6.4 billion kronor and 8 years of human time. That money could have paid for two more bridges — or schools, or hospitals. Instead, it was spent on a simulation of democratic process.

Case conclusion: This example is not about ecologists or unions being unimportant. It is about a system in which every "interested voice" has the right to stop any decision — which is not democracy. It is an engineering catastrophe disguised as civic participation. ERC 'Earth' separated the "right to a voice" (preserved for everyone) from the "right of veto" (belonging only to those whose expertise is directly relevant to the specific task). The efficiency difference: fivefold.

12.4. The Law of "Competence Erosion"

The Apostles of Common Sense identified a critical threshold: when P exceeds 10, the governance system stops solving the stated task and begins exclusively self-serving. By 2037, the average P in Triad state projects had reached 14.

12.5. The Engineers' Sermon: A Change of Paradigm

— **Political decision:** "We believe taxes should be raised to build a bright future." (An opinion that cannot be verified.)

— **Engineering decision:** "Optimising transport flows in sector A-12 will reduce energy consumption by 14.2% and free 1.2 billion resource units." (A calculation that is verifiable.)

Summary: A politician is a middleman who takes a 90% commission for getting in the way of the craftsman's work. When 8 billion residents saw this formula, the "moment of enlightenment" arrived: people understood that they are not "citizens of countries" — they are "investors in the process of life maintenance." The Apostles of Common Sense offered not a new faith. They offered a new calculator.

Chapter 13. The Revolution of Exhaustion: When It Burns

The revolutions of the past were made in the name of ideas: freedom, equality, or divine right. The revolution of 2037 was the first in history made in the name of working plumbing. This was not an explosion of passion — it was an explosion of wear.

"Evils which are patiently endured when they seem inevitable, become intolerable when once the idea of escape from them is suggested." — Alexis de Tocqueville, The Old Regime and the Revolution

13.1. The Loyalty Amortisation Coefficient

The Apostles of Common Sense introduced the concept of loyalty amortisation — a mathematical quantity showing how quickly a citizen stops trusting their government when reality diverges from the news feed:

$$Al = \int_{t_0}^{t_1} [D(t) - R(t)] / P(t) \cdot dt$$

Where:

Al — (Amortisation of Loyalty) — the rate at which trust in the governance system is destroyed

D(t) — (Digital Illusion) — promises and propaganda broadcast by the state

R(t) — (Reality) — the real state of infrastructure and quality of life

P(t) — (Price of participation) — taxes, inflation, risk of mobilisation

t₀—t₁ — observation time interval

When the *Al* integral exceeded critical mass, a "social phase transition" occurred. People did not take to the squares. People simply left the system.

Three Triggers That Drove the *Al* Coefficient to Critical Values

By 2037, three circumstances converged simultaneously, each of which the system would have survived in isolation — but not all three at once.

— **Inflation of everyday life:** By 2037, the basic basket (food + energy + housing) was consuming 85% of the average middle-class income. When "freedom of choice" comes down to choosing between heating and food, rhetoric about "free societies" loses all meaning.

— **Infrastructure infarction:** In 2025–2032, systemic blackouts lasting more than 12 hours occurred in 40 major world cities. When a "smart home" has no water for three days, talk of national greatness sounds like mockery.

— **The "Useless Sacrifice" Crisis:** Triad attempts to revive "mobilisation collectivism" met the deaf resistance of millennials and zoomers raised in the global network, who refused to die for borders they considered a software error.

13.2. The Mechanics of "Quiet Resignation"

— **Tax desertion:** Mass exodus to cryptocurrencies and barter communities.

- **Information vacuum:** *Ratings of political shows fell to zero. People switched en masse to dumbphones and local mesh networks.*
- **Border ignorance:** *Millions of people began moving across the planet ignoring visa regimes.*

Analytical conclusion: Politics runs on our attention and our consent to consider it important. The moment we acknowledged it as secondary to the functioning of the elevator, it collapsed like a house of cards.

Chapter 14. The Engineers' Sermon: The World as Net Profit

When the politicians' shouting died down, new voices came over the airwaves. These were people with eyes red from sleep deprivation, in crumpled hoodies and greasy overalls. They were called the "Apostles of Common Sense." Their sermon promised not salvation of the soul — it promised a working elevator and a full bowl of food.

14.1. The Lost Opportunity Equation

The Apostles presented humanity with a global audit of expenditure. The Lost Opportunity Equation (L_{op}):

$$L_p^o = (M^b + P^d) \times k_r^f$$

Where:

- L_p^o — (Lost Opportunity) — *resources burning in the furnace of "national greatness"*
- M^b — (Military Budgets) — *combined global military spending (\$2.5 trillion/year by 2037)*
- P^d — (Political Distortions) — *direct losses from trade wars, sanctions, and customs barriers*
- k_r^f — (Friction Coefficient) — *losses of time and talent servicing borders and bureaucracy*

The engineers proved that humanity annually burns in the furnace of "national greatness" enough resources to completely eliminate hunger, provide every resident with clean water, and create a high-speed transport network across the planet within 36 months.

14.2. Technological Determinism Instead of Ideologies

- **Unification is cheap:** *Why do we need 200 different standards for sockets, laws, and currencies? Standardising the planet cuts the cost of living by a factor of four.*
- **No secrecy is fast:** *When engineers from the US, China, and Russia share data directly, the speed of solving global problems grows exponentially.*
- **Peace is profit:** *War is the destruction of assets. Peace is the creation of added value.*

Chapter conclusion: The "Apostles of Common Sense" accomplished the impossible: they made "Peace" sexy and profitable. They transformed the "Enemy" from an existential threat into a technical error in the resource distribution system.

Chapter 15. Signing the Contract: The Great Liquidation of Sovereignty

In May 2037, an event occurred that future historians will call "the Great Cancellation." 8 billion people did not take to the streets — they simply ticked the box "I accept the terms of the new user agreement."

15.1. The Legal Basis: From "Citizen" to "Beneficiary"

The Apostles prepared a document radically different from any constitution of the past. At its core lay the concept of Sovereignty Utility:

$$U_s = \frac{S^b - C_m}{R_t}$$

Where:

U_s — (Sovereignty Utility) — the net value of the state for the resident

S^b — (Social Benefits) — real services received by the resident

C_m — (Maintenance Cost) — taxes, inflation, bureaucratic overheads

R_t — (Risk Transformation) — probability of war, sanctions, or mobilisation

When calculations showed that in all regions of the Triad, U_s had gone negative — the state was consuming more resources and creating more risks than it was providing in benefits — the legal justification for states' existence vanished.

15.2. The Signing Mechanics: The "Zero-Knowledge" Technology

— **Distributed consensus:** Signing occurred via decentralised mesh networks. Your Skill-ID served as a unique key.

— **Zero-Knowledge Proof:** The system allowed verification of a signatory's identity without revealing their location to the old Management Companies.

— **Fact:** In the first 72 hours after the Contract was published, more than 4.2 billion people signed. By the end of the month the number exceeded 7.5 billion.

15.3. The Five Pillars of the Contract

- **Infrastructural connectivity:** A ban on any restriction of the movement of people, goods, or information.
- **Resource audit:** All mineral resources and energy sources placed under management of a transparent distribution algorithm.
- **Security as a Service:** Dissolution of national armies. Military budgets transferred to the "Global Shield" fund.
- **Unified Skill-ID:** Abolition of passports. Your status is determined by your real contribution.
- **The Right to go Offline (Reservations):** Legal recognition of the right to opt out of the system.

Programmatic conclusion: The Contract is not the loss of your freedom. It is the acquisition of ownership of your planet. You are no longer a "tenant" of your life, with a "landlord" in a tie making decisions for you. You are a shareholder of the global corporation "Humanity."

PART V THE ARCHITECTURE OF ERC 'EARTH': MECHANICS OF PEACE

A technical description of a grown-up civilisation.

Chapter 16. City Managers Instead of Leaders: The Era of Invisible Governance

The old world suffered from the "cult of personality." We elected people who knew how to make beautiful promises, stare heroically into the camera, and find enemies under the bed. In ERC 'Earth', this is recognised as a serious system malfunction.

*"Management is doing things right; leadership is doing the right things." —
Peter Drucker, The Effective Executive (1967)*

The ERC 'Earth' architects made a radical choice: they chose management over leadership. No more vision, mission, and national destiny. The city manager's role is to ensure the water is clean and the rubbish is collected on time.

16.1. The Deconstruction of Charisma

In 2037, charisma was officially added to the list of "professional contraindications" for administrative posts. Statistical analysis showed a correlation between a leader's oratorical skill and the level of corruption in their department.

16.2. The Administrative Quality Formula (AQ)

Instead of approval ratings, the AQ Index is used, calculated in real time:

$$AQ = \frac{U_r + H_s + E_a + L_x}{C^b}$$

Where:

AQ — (Administrative Quality) — overall effectiveness rating of governance

U_r — (Utility Reliability) — uninterrupted supply of water, power, communications

H_s — (Health & Safety) — objective health and security indicators in the sector

E_a — (Environmental Assets) — ecosystem restoration index

L_x — (Logistics Cost) — reduction in time for people and goods to travel

C^b — (*Cost of Bureaucracy*) — expenditure on the governance apparatus itself; if it grows faster than the numerator — the manager is automatically dismissed

16.3. From "Power" to "Service"

- **Absence of ideological superstructure:** *The manager cannot have a "personal opinion" on history or morality. His task is the rubbish, the energy, the medicine.*
- **Transparency 24/7:** *Every cent from the ERC's common fund spent by the manager is visible in a public registry.*
- **Replaceability as hygiene:** *The manager works as long as their AQ is above the planetary average.*

Johannes Braun wakes at 5:47 a.m. not from an alarm — the system knows his sleep cycle and raises the room temperature by half a degree. He is the city manager of the Rhine-Ruhr Agglomeration, 11.3 million residents.

His first task of the day: an anomaly in the G-14 water supply sector. During the night, sensors recorded a 4.2% pressure drop; the system automatically rerouted load to the backup circuit. The anomaly has been resolved without his intervention. Johannes reviews the log — this takes 90 seconds.

At 2 p.m. his working day ends. Johannes's AQ today: 94.7 out of 100. His face is not recognised in the street. The lights are on in the homes.

Chapter 17. Blockchain Legislation: Law as Executable Code

In the old world, law was a linguistic labyrinth. Laws were written by humans for humans, but in such a way that only specially trained high priests — lawyers — could decipher them. In ERC 'Earth', law ceased to be text on paper. It became a protocol.

17.1. From the "Letter of the Law" to the "Smart Contract"

In ERC 'Earth', legislation works on the principle of Self-Executing Law. If residents vote to limit speed in a residential zone to 30 km/h, the system simply physically caps the speed of all autonomous vehicles. We need no inspectors, courts, or appeals.

17.2. The Social Consensus Function

For adopting new rules, a dynamic vote-weighting formula is used — Quadratic Voting integrated with Skill-ID:

$$S^c = \sum_{i=1}^n V_i \times K^{\text{exp}}$$

$$i=1$$

Where:

- S^c — (Social Consensus) — weighted result of the vote
- V_i — the number of influence tokens resident i is willing to spend on the decision
- K^{exp} — (Expertise Coefficient) — calculated from the resident's Skill-ID in the relevant domain

If a question involves building a fusion reactor, a nuclear physicist's vote weighs significantly more than a popular blogger's. This is not discrimination — it is protection against incompetence.

17.3. Global Parameters vs. Local Rules

Level	Responsibility	Example
Global (Core)	Immutable constants of ERC 'Earth'	Ban on violence, freedom of movement, ecosystem integrity
Local (Sectors)	Configurable parameters of agglomerations	Quiet hours, local budget allocation, building quotas

Seoul-Busan Agglomeration, 19 million residents. February 2037. Park So-yeon, an ecological architect, initiated a bill on mandatory rooftop greening for all new buildings above six storeys. First 48 hours: automatic validation. Next 72 hours: simulation. Voting lasted 7 days: 68% weighted vote — in favour. No parliamentary hearings. No lobbyists. The law was adopted without her. That was the design.

Chapter 18. AI Arbitration: Justice Without Emotion and "Special Circumstances"

In the old world, justice was the slowest and most expensive attraction. The psychological phenomenon of the "hungry judge effect" (sentences being harsher just before lunch) was a verdict on the very idea of human justice. In ERC 'Earth', courts became a Data Arbitration system.

18.1. The End of "Advocacy Fables"

In AI Arbitration, the art of oratory does not exist. The objective truth formula on which the system runs:

$$F^d \times W_v$$

$$J_a^I = \lim_{\Delta \rightarrow 0} \frac{\text{-----}}{L^{\text{code}}}$$

Where:

J_a^I — (Justice AI) — the objectivity of the decision, approaching the absolute

F^d — (Fact Data) — verified data with cryptographic signature

W_v — (Witness Veracity) — reliability coefficient of testimony, including biometrics

L^{code} — (Legal Code) — the smart contract protocol governing this domain

$\Delta \rightarrow 0$ — the margin of human interpretation, approaching zero

18.2. The Death of Corruption: The Algorithm Has No Pocket

- **No personal interests:** *The machine has no children to place at university and no villa to save up for.*
- **Logic tree audit:** *Every Arbitration decision is accompanied by an Explaining Log — a visualisation of the logical chain.*
- **Irreversibility:** *The Arbitration decision is executed by the system automatically. A politician cannot call "their judge."*

Bangalore cluster, March 2037. A dispute between engineer Rajesh Nair and the logistics company "Silk Node Asia." The Arbitration analysed the data. Key fact: the input data provided by the company showed a 4.1% discrepancy with production data. Decision: the company pays Rajesh the remaining 40% of the amount, plus compensation. Time from application to enforcement: 0.42 seconds for analysis, 48 hours for enforcement. In the old world, this dispute would have gone to court. Minimum — 14 months. Legal services cost — around \$40,000.

Chapter 19. Security Guard Instead of Gendarme: Service Police Without the Right to "Opinions"

In the old world, police were the "sovereign's eye" and "the punishing sword." The gendarme was an instrument of ideological violence: he could beat you for the wrong placard. In ERC 'Earth', police as a political institution has been liquidated. It has been replaced by the Public Safety Service (PSS).

19.1. Depoliticisation of the Uniform: From "Power" to "Function"

A PSS officer is an emergency commissioner for issues of physical conflict. His protocol activates only in cases of physical violation of another resident's boundaries or common property. If the AI Arbitration detects no criminal element in a resident's actions, the officer's equipment simply does not activate.

19.2. The Safety Score Index (S_s)

PSS effectiveness is measured not by number of arrests, but by the Safety Score:

$$S_s = \frac{T_r \times C_s}{I^c}$$

Where:

S_s — (Safety Score) — integral performance indicator of PSS work

T_r — (Response Time) — speed of arrival at the scene of conflict

C_s — (Conflicts Solved) — percentage of conflicts resolved without force

I^c — (Incident Count) — total number of incidents in the sector; the higher this is, the lower the S_s

Lima-Callao, class B agglomeration, April 2037, 22:47. Officer Carla Medina arrives at the call in 4 minutes 12 seconds. A parking spot dispute. Arbitration requests data — 0.42 seconds. Decision automatic: the violator's smart vehicle receives a self-relocation command. Medina spends 11 minutes on site. No arrest. Her C_s score for this quarter: 97.3%.

Chapter 20. A World Without Borders: The Liquidation of "Territorial Ghettos"

In the old world, borders were the main "bug" in the planet's operating system. They existed so that some Management Companies could keep their "clients" inside, preventing them from comparing rates and service quality with the neighbours. In 2037, after the Contract was signed, borders became administrative artefacts, drained of political weight.

20.1. The Death of the "Foreigner" and the Triumph of Skill-ID

The concept of "foreigner" in ERC 'Earth' has been officially recognised as outdated and discriminatory. Your passport is replaced by a Skill-ID, which gives you the right of access to any point on the planet where your competencies are in demand.

20.2. The Global Connectivity Index (GCI)

$$GCI = \frac{T_p + L_v \times B_u}{}$$

$$F^c$$

Where:

GCI — (*Global Connectivity Index*) — speed of movement of people, goods, and data

T_p — (*Transport Proximity*) — average access time from point A to any point B

L_v — (*Logistics Velocity*) — speed at which cargo moves through hubs

B_u — (*Bandwidth*) — of information and energy channels

F^c — (*Friction Coefficient*) — residual bureaucratic or technical delays; any border is a blood clot

Aissa Diallo was born in Dakar. In 2037 she is 34, a specialist in hydroponic systems. In the morning a proposal arrives from the Rotterdam Agglomeration. She accepts. At 14:30 her autonomous capsule train enters the maglev corridor. Twelve hours later she is in Rotterdam. No passports. Her Skill-ID is verified automatically at every transit node.

PART VI THE HUMAN IN THE SYSTEM: HEROISM WITHOUT BLOODSHED

Where to put ambition?

Chapter 21. The Sublimation of Aggression: K2 in Flip-Flops and the Laboratories of Rage

We are biological predators. Millions of years of evolution sharpened our brains for dominance, expansion, and the elimination of rivals. If you take war away from people and offer them nothing in exchange, they will tear ERC 'Earth' apart from the inside — out of sheer boredom.

"So far, war has been the only force that can discipline a whole community, and until an equivalent discipline is organized, I believe that war must have its way." — William James, The Moral Equivalent of War (1906)

James wrote this in 1906 — and was a prophet. His essay was the first serious argument for exactly what ERC 'Earth' built: not the elimination of the martial spirit, but its redirection. The argument in his words: we need a moral equivalent of war. Something that demands the same discipline, courage, and sacrifice — but does not kill.

21.1. The Sublimation Coefficient (A_{su}^b)

To manage the human drive, the concept of sublimated aggression was introduced:

$$A_{su}^b = \frac{D \times O}{H_{so}^c}$$

Where:

A_{su}^b — (Sublimation Coefficient) — useful yield of aggressive drive

D — (Drive) — internal aggression level: the urge for dominance and overcoming

O — (Overcoming) — the difficulty of the obstacle: biological limit, scientific mystery, physical record

H_{so}^c — (Social Harm) — damage to other residents; in the ideal case, approaches zero

This is not a call to "curb instincts." This is an engineering approach: aggression is energy. Energy has two paths — blow up the neighbour's house, or power a turbine. ERC 'Earth' does not try to reduce D — that is pointless. It works to maximise O (there is a worthy obstacle) and zero out H_{soc} (no one is harmed).

21.2. "K2 in Flip-Flops": Rebranding Heroism

Old wars were attempts to prove the superiority of one flag over another. Now, heroism is an attempt to prove the superiority of reason over biology. "K2 in flip-flops" is a metaphor for supreme achievement. Want to prove you're an alpha? Climb an eight-thousander without oxygen, in shorts, using only your body's thermoregulation. Or cross Greenland alone. Or live for two weeks in the Sahara with three litres of water.

Former soldiers are actively hired for Mars expeditions and asteroid belt missions — places that need people capable of decisions under limited oxygen, without delay, without a second chance. Mortality there is no lower than in the trenches of old, but every person who dies is not a "victim of a regime" but a "hero of expansion." Their names are remembered. Their children are provided for. Their Skill-ID becomes a historical document posthumously.

21.3. Scientific "Crusades"

Triad research centres became a kind of "digital fronts." Scientists battle for patents, for a breakthrough in fusion power or decoding the genome of ageing with the same ferocity as generals of the past planned offensive operations. In 2037, "taking the high ground" means being first to launch a next-generation quantum computer. "Breaking through defences" — beating the physical limits of lithium-ion batteries. "Securing a bridgehead" — staking a patent position in a new class of biomaterials.

These competitions have all the signs of war, except one: the loser is not dead. At worst, they move on to the next problem. The energy of confrontation remains. The casualties vanish.

21.4. Gladiatorial Contests 2.0: Cyberspace and VR

For those whose aggression requires a visual of blood and combat, Zones of Full Immersion were created. Millions of people daily "blow off steam" in hyperrealistic simulations of historical wars. You can be Napoleon, Zhukov, Patton, or simply a private at the Somme. You feel pain, fear, and triumph — but when you remove the headset, you have not a scratch, and your real neighbour is still your friend.

ERC 'Earth' psychologists discovered a curious side effect: people who regularly go through VR wars become less inclined to support real ones. Knowing what it "looks like from the inside" cures romanticisation. Heroic rhetoric works poorly on those who yesterday were personally carrying their "own" out from under a simulated artillery barrage.

21.5. Competitions Without Winners: A New Class of Games

Alongside the gladiatorial arenas, a new format developed — "collaborative trials." Teams of 20–50 people receive a task only achievable with perfect coordination (a roped ascent, an ocean crossing by sail without engine, building a temporary settlement in Antarctica in 72

hours). There are no winners. There are "teams that completed the task" and "teams that withdrew mid-way."

This addressed the biological demand for collective action under conditions of risk — previously satisfied only by military service. The phenomenon proved massive: by 2037, around 12% of ERC 'Earth' residents participated in some such trial at least once a year.

Leon Kovačević is 41. In his former life — a Serbian special forces officer, three combat deployments. In 2031, when his unit was disbanded as part of Europe-wide demilitarisation, Leon was left with a problem he could barely articulate but felt acutely: he was made for struggle — and there was nothing left to struggle for.

In 2033 he happened to see a livestream of the first "Technology Assault" — a competition where engineering and science teams were given an unsolved technical problem and 72 hours to solve it. The format was structured like a military operation: headquarters, reconnaissance, hypothesis attacks, data counterattacks, a final "assault" on the solution. Leon didn't understand a word of the problem statement. But he recognised something in these people: they were fierce with concentration, they weren't sleeping, they were ready to kill their opponent.

He applied to engineering school via the "Second Skill-ID" special programme. He was 38, with no degree in physics or computer science — but with experience of making decisions under data scarcity and time pressure. That, it turned out, is a valuable skill. He specialised in thermal processes in urban infrastructure. In March 2037, Leon's team won the Technology Assault in the "Urban Cluster Cooling" category.

At the award ceremony, he was asked: "What does a win like this feel like?" He answered without pause: "Exactly the same. Except this time nobody died. And I finally understand what all of it was for."

Chapter 22. Symbiosis of Roles: Visionaries and Executors

In the old world, there existed a pernicious caste system. At the top of the pyramid sat those who "traded in air" — visionaries, strategists. At the foot — those who actually turned the bolts. We'd grown accustomed to thinking that whoever invented the trainers was infinitely more important than whoever sewed them. In ERC 'Earth', this pyramid was dismantled.

22.1. The Total Value Equation (V_{oal}^t)

$$V_{oal}^t = I \times E$$

Where:

V_{oal}^t — (Total Value) — the overall useful result of the project

I — (Idea) — conceptual power, concept complexity, innovation

E — (Execution) — precision of realisation, material quality, durability of result

The mathematics is merciless: if your brilliant idea ($I \approx \infty$) is multiplied by terrible execution ($E \approx 0$), the result is negligible. In ERC 'Earth', the visionary and the executor each receive an equal percentage of the product's total value.

22.2. Skill-ID: The Rehabilitation of Craft

In 2037, the status "Master" became the most prestigious title. The Skill-ID of a welder capable of a perfect vacuum weld is comparable to that of the chief architect. If you are the best baker in your sector, your access level to ERC's benefits may be higher than that of an average programmer.

Hamid Akgün — conceptual architect, Skill-ID 82.1. Gül Demirtaş — sixth-grade welder, Skill-ID 76.8. She wrote to him directly: "Your connection nodes — there is no material that will hold these loads." In the old world, that note would have been ignored. In ERC 'Earth', every project participant has a right of technical veto. Hamid replied within two hours. They worked together for eight months. When asked "who's in charge?", Hamid answered: "Whoever the bridge would have fallen without."

Chapter 23. Boredom as a Resource: The Curse and Gift of Free Time

Welcome to the most frightening department of ERC 'Earth' — the department of having nothing to do. In the old world we were taught that "idleness is the mother of all vice." In 2037, when AI had automated everything with an algorithm, humanity had generated a colossal surplus of time.

"We work in order to have leisure." — Aristotle, Politics, Book VII

23.1. The Free Attention Formula (A^{free})

$$A^{\text{free}} = T_{\text{otal}}^{\text{t}} - (T_{\text{m}} + T_{\text{s}})$$

Where:

A^{free} — (Free Attention) — hours of pure personal time every 24 hours

$T_{\text{otal}}^{\text{t}}$ — 24 hours in a day

T_{m} — (Biology) — sleep, food, hygiene

T_{s} — (Service labour) — socially useful contribution (≈ 2.5 hours/day in 2037)

The average resident freed up around 10–12 hours of completely pure time. ERC 'Earth' is the first civilisation to recognise this time as "raw material for evolution."

23.2. The "Flies on the Ceiling" Study

Gazing at flies on the ceiling is a metaphor for deep internal audit. When external stimuli disappear, the brain begins generating meanings from within. ERC 'Earth' is the first civilisation to make the state of "insight" a mass product — simply by stopping the constant nagging of people over trivialities.

Meilin Zhou was a data analyst in her former life. In 2034, AI automated 80% of her functions. For the first two months she didn't know what to do with the freed-up time. In the third month she accidentally started reading about oceanography. Six months later she wrote a paper. Three days after that, an oceanographer with Skill-ID 84.6 wrote to her. Two years later they published a joint paper. She says: "In my old life I always felt I was running late. Now I feel like there's infinity ahead."

PART VII RESERVATIONS: THE RIGHT TO GO OFFLINE

On those who chose "the weight of reality."

Chapter 24. Digital Asceticism: The Right to "The Weight of Reality"

In a world where the AI Arbitration anticipates your desires and city managers provide absolute comfort, a new, most elite form of deviation emerged — a thirst for environmental resistance. Some residents realised that "the perfect life" lacks weight. When everything works at the click of a button, the very concept of "achievement" is devalued.

24.1. The Authenticity of Being Coefficient (A^b)

$$A^b = \frac{P\varphi \times C_m}{S_a}$$

Where:

A^b — (Authenticity of Being) — how much you are truly living, rather than through an interface

$P\varphi$ — (Physical Friction) — amount of physical effort required for survival

C_m — (Causal Manifestation) — direct cause-and-effect link: swing a hammer, drive a nail

S_a — (System Assistance) — degree of AI and automation involvement; in Reservations, approaches zero

24.2. The Architecture of "Zero Signal"

Reservations are territories legally withdrawn from global network coverage. Within 100 kilometres of the centre of a Reservation, "passive shields" block all external signals. Inside the Reservation, Skill-currency does not apply. Here the currency is barter, promise, and personal authority.

24.3. The Psychology of "The Weight of Reality"

— **Dopamine reset:** *The pleasure of a mug of fresh milk after an hour of hand-milking is greater than any virtual simulator.*

— **Existential risk:** *In a Reservation, you can freeze if you didn't stock the wood. This risk returns to life its genuine sharpness.*

— **Death of the simulacrum:** *Here you are not your Skill-ID. You are how you hold an axe and how you behave when the neighbour's barn is on fire.*

Tomasz Nowak arrived at the Carpathian Reservation in October 2036. Former software architect, Skill-ID 79.4. A good salary in the Krakow agglomeration, a respected position, full digital comfort. And a feeling he himself described as "living through glass — you can see everything, but feel nothing."

The first two weeks were humiliation. He couldn't chop wood to last the night. The stove didn't hold heat — because he was closing the damper wrong. The bread didn't rise three times in a row. He frostbit his fingers because he didn't know gloves are dried from the inside, not the outside.

By January he had learned. Not everything — but enough. He understood that physical exhaustion is different from mental exhaustion. After 8 hours with an axe and a saw, he slept without dreams. In February he began noticing the sound of how snow changes its creak at different temperatures.

In spring 2037 he could have returned to Krakow — his Skill-ID was not cancelled. He stayed. Not out of ideology — he simply realised he didn't want to go back. Once a month he walks to the village on the edge of the Reservation, where a terminal works, and records a 30-minute audio file for the agglomeration archive: on how to fix old mechanical locks, how to read snow, how to negotiate with a neighbour when there is no arbitration. That is his "tax to the system" — the only link to the external ERC. The rest of the time he simply lives.

Asked by a journalist what the most important thing he had learned in eighteen months was, Tomasz answered: "I finally know why I'm doing what I do. Before — I didn't. It turns out that matters."

Chapter 25. The Garden as Fitness: The Economics of Sweat and Manure

In the old world, fitness was an absurd simulacrum: people paid money to lift pieces of iron they had no need to move in an air-conditioned gym. In ERC 'Earth's' Reservations, fitness reclaimed its original meaning — the transformation of matter.

"We must cultivate our garden — it is the only way to make life tolerable." — Voltaire, Candide

25.1. The Bio-Productivity Coefficient (K_p^b)

$$K_p^b = \frac{\Delta M}{\Delta E_{io}^b}$$

Where:

K_p^b — (Bio-Productivity) — efficiency of converting bodily energy into real results

ΔM — (Matter Change) — real physical change in the world: a dug bed, a built shed, a harvested crop

ΔE_{io}^b — (Biological Energy) — calories spent and litres of sweat shed

25.2. The Psychology of "Bone Weariness"

ERC 'Earth' physicians recorded the phenomenon: "tiredness in the bones" (after physical labour) cures depression more effectively than any AI therapist, while "tiredness in the eyes" (after a monitor) only provokes it. The dopamine cycle "soil → mouth" — plant a seed, water it, eat the fruit three months later — gives the brain the most ancient and most powerful success signal. There is no room in this cycle for "impostor syndrome." You cannot pretend to be a good farmer. The tomatoes either grew or they didn't.

25.3. The Economics of "Spade and Manure"

Here, "promises" are not believed. You helped your neighbour fix their roof? You earned a share of the harvest or a return favour. Being the owner of fertile land in 2037 confers greater status than owning a penthouse in virtual New York.

Fatima al-Hashimi had not planned to become a farmer. She was a financial analyst in the Dubai cluster. In 2034 she moved to the "Wadi" agricultural reservation in southern Jordan. The first year she ran at a loss — she couldn't read the soil. The second year, the farm broke even. The third — turned a profit. She says: "A vegetable garden is an honest system. If you did it right, it grows. If not — it doesn't. There are no meetings about it."

Chapter 26. Humanity's Backup Copy: The Insurance Policy for a Fragile World

In 2037, when 99% of planetary processes are managed by algorithms, a reasonable question arose: what will happen if "the switch" goes off? If a powerful solar flare or a critical AI error wipes our Skill-IDs and turns "smart homes" into concrete tombs?

Reservations are not a zoo for technophobes. They are the Global Repository of Biological Skills. The "cold storage" of humanity's very essence.

26.1. The System Fragility Coefficient (S_ψ)

$$S_\psi = \frac{D \times C}{R_a}$$

Where:

S_ψ — (System Fragility) — probability of collapse in the event of failure

D — (*Dependency*) — the level of society's dependence on electricity grids and the internet

C — (*Complexity*) — the number of intermediate links in the logistics chain

R_a — (*Analogue Resilience*) — percentage of population capable of surviving without machines; in megacities ≈ 0 , in Reservations ≈ 1

26.2. The Guardians of "Tacit Knowledge"

There is a stratum of knowledge that cannot be digitised. You can read a million PDFs about metalworking, but you won't "feel" the temperature of metal by its colour until you have spent ten years at the forge.

The Reservations hold skills of manual obstetrics, traditional medicine, stellar navigation, and primitive metallurgy. This is the "biological backup" of civilisation.

26.3. The "Rollback Point" Protocol

In the event of a global ERC 'Earth' system crash, the "Rollback" protocol activates. Reservations become the crystallisation centres of a new order. From there will emerge the people who know how to start a steam engine, organise defence without drones, and restore agriculture from scratch.

October 2036. At 03:17, an X9.3 solar flare knocked out the satellite constellation. Northern European agglomerations lost connection with the global network for 11 hours 43 minutes. Managed chaos began in the megacities. In the Carpathian Reservation, Jan Kubera was feeding his chickens that morning. When a journalist asked him two weeks later: "How do you feel about that?" — he answered: "No particular way. I'd been running low on wood that day. That was what I was thinking about."

CONCLUSION

Adult life has begun.

Chapter 27. Adult Life: The World Where "They" Are Gone

In 2037, humanity officially concluded its "adolescent" period. "They" are simply us, in a different time zone with different inputs. The maturation of a species is the transition from drama to administration.

27.1. The Psychological Deconstruction of the Enemy

In ERC 'Earth's logic, any conflict is treated not as grounds for rage but as a system error. If someone hinders the system's functioning — they are not an "evil genius," they are a malfunctioning node. We don't go to war with the node; we repair or reprogram it.

27.2. The Civilisational Yield Coefficient (E^{yield})

$$E^{\text{yield}} = \frac{E^{\text{dev}} - E^{\text{deψ}}}{E^{\text{t}}_{\text{oal}}}$$

Where:

E^{yield} — (Civilization Yield) — humanity's efficiency ratio; in the old world 0.15–0.20, in 2037 — 0.85

E^{dev} — (Development Energy) — science, infrastructure, art

$E^{\text{deψ}}$ — (Defense/Confrontation Energy) — burned in the furnace of "protecting interests," propaganda, and weapons

$E^{\text{t}}_{\text{oal}}$ — (Total Energy) — humanity's aggregate potential

27.3. The World as Global Backlog

Old paradigm (War)	New paradigm (Task)	Tools
"We need to seize this region"	"Water deficit in this sector: 14%"	China's logistics (The Factory)
"These people are our enemies"	"This group has low Skill-ID adaptation"	US education protocols (The Brand)

Old paradigm (War)	New paradigm (Task)	Tools
"Defend our values"	"Maintain energy balance in the sector"	Russia's reactors (The Engine)

Ingrid Lindström writes a letter to her son Erik on paper. "Erik, this morning I had coffee by the window and was thinking: I don't know a single enemy. Not in the sense that I have no one I disagree with — Ulrika from the flat next door and I still argue about the noise-after-10pm rule. But an enemy — a person I wish harm simply because they are different — there is none. I think that is what adulthood looks like. Not triumph. Not victory. Simply silence where there used to be noise. Take care of yourself. Write. Mum."

Chapter 28. Three Failed ERC Projects: The Price of Mistakes Without Which There Would Be No Success

The history of ERC 'Earth' is not a history of inevitable victory. It is a history of attempts, most of which failed. Not one of the Apostles will tell you they knew how to do it right. They only knew how — not to.

Case I: "New Geneva" (2031–2033) — Death by Idealism

In 2031, a consortium of 140 engineers and economists from 23 countries created the first fully "post-state" enclave in the mountains of Georgia. The charter was impeccable: horizontal governance, AI Arbitration, blockchain voting. The first six months were euphoria. On the eighth month the water supply system broke down. The vote on who was responsible for fixing it lasted nine days.

Lesson: *Horizontality is good for planning. A breakdown demands a vertical. Democracy works in planning mode. Emergency protocol works in command mode. Mixing them is fatal.*

Case II: "Free Port Tunisia" (2032–2034) — Death by Internal Corruption

In June 2033, an independent auditor discovered that Arbitration decisions on land disputes were systematically deviating 0.7–1.2% in favour of companies affiliated with the founders. The deviation was invisible to a non-specialist. Over 14 months, it represented an asset redistribution of around €180 million.

Lesson: *No system can be more honest than the people servicing it. ERC 'Earth's' architecture solved this through radical separation of physical infrastructure between all three Triad members.*

Case III: "Catalonia-2 Autonomy" (2033–2035) — Death by External Pressure

Resident satisfaction: 87%. Municipal procurement corruption: down 94% over two years. Madrid shut the project in December 2034. Formal grounds: violation of legislation on currency issuance. Real grounds: the demonstration effect.

Lesson: *A new system cannot exist as an enclave inside the old one if the old system is strong enough to destroy it. ERC 'Earth' only became possible because by 2037 the states had weakened to the point where they could not afford to fight what worked better.*

Analytical conclusion: Each of the three failures pointed to a weakness that needed sealing. "New Geneva" showed that horizontality without an emergency vertical is dysfunction. "Free Port" showed that the system's openness must include the openness of its own infrastructure. "Catalonia-2" showed that a window of opportunity exists — and cannot be missed. Without these three deaths, the right answer would have been found another twenty years later.

Chapter 29. Those Who Didn't Join: Resistance With Meaning

An honest book about a new world must speak not only of those who believed in it. It must speak of those who refused — and of why they were, in their own way, right. ERC 'Earth' was not adopted unanimously.

29.1. Nationalist Statists: The Loss of Identity as a Real Fear

The largest resistance group numbered around 400 million. Their argument ran: "We are not simply a collection of competencies with a Skill-ID. We are the language our grandmother spoke. We are the cemetery where our grandfather lies. None of that can be digitised — and you are not even trying."

By 2040, most nationalist movements had evolved into cultural communities within ERC — preserving identity while abandoning its political form of expression.

29.2. Religious Leaders: Power That Lost Its Monopoly on Meaning

ERC 'Earth' did not ban or restrict religious practice — it simply stopped funding religious institutions from the common budget. It gradually emerged that sincere support existed — it was simply less than the institutions themselves had supposed. Personal faith remained. Clerical power — contracted.

29.3. Military Elites: A Profession Without an Employer

Around 2 million people, whose identity was built on the professional application of force, lost their professional purpose. Some moved into the PSS. Some into technological sublimation programmes: space expeditions, technological competitions. By 2045, most of

these enclaves had quietly joined — when a younger generation grew up for whom "the warrior's honour" was a less comprehensible concept than access to education and healthcare.

29.4. Simply People Who Were Frightened

The quietest and largest group. Their fear was concrete: "I don't understand how this works. I don't understand who I call if something goes wrong."

In the end, every agglomeration created "Navigation Centres" — live people whose job was to explain to other live people how the system worked. The phenomenon turned out to be unexpected: the most frequent topic of enquiry was not "how do I receive a service" — but "explain to me who is responsible for this."

Analytical conclusion: Each resistance group pointed to something the system had initially not accounted for. Nationalists — to the fact that identity is not reducible to efficiency. Religious leaders — to the fact that the meaning of life cannot be written into a smart contract. Military elites — to the fact that a person needs to feel strong. Frightened ordinary people — to the fact that the system's transparency must be not only technical but human. ERC 'Earth' became better because of the resistance — not in spite of it.

EPILOGUE: THE HAUERS IN 2037

Four generations. Eighty years. One story — closed.

Through the four acts of Part I, we lived alongside one family from Dortmund. Werner saw the Button. Klaus saw the credit card. Sara saw the algorithm. And Sara saw what none of her ancestors had seen: the moment when "normal" stopped being normal.

The book owes it to the reader to close this story. Otherwise the Hauer family will remain frozen in 2023, at two in the morning, with an electricity bill in hand. That is not fair — to them or to you.

| *Berlin Agglomeration, May 2037. Two days after the signing of the Contract.*

Sara Hauer-Lorand (she married in 2030 and kept both names — now technically possible and requiring no one's permission) sits in the office of the Navigation Centre, sector Berlin-Mitte. She is 42. Skill-ID 71.4 — average but steady: moderator-consultant, specialisation "adapting people over 50 to the new system."

In front of her — a man of around sixty. Not aggressive. Simply at a loss. He asks: "Could you explain, please. If I stop working — who pays for my medicine? I've paid taxes my whole life. I didn't understand them, but I paid them. Who do I go to now?"

Sara hears this question twenty times a week. She knows the protocol. She knows the man has a basic life-support package by default — healthcare included. She knows she needs to explain it simply, without acronyms, without the word "algorithm."

But before she begins to explain, she remembers something else.

Fourteen years ago she lay in the dark staring at the ceiling. The electricity bill. The salary falling in real terms. Three degrees. Nobody explaining what comes next. She remembers clearly the colour of the ceiling then. Grey, with a dark stain from an old leak.

She leans towards the man. "Your name is Horst? Horst, let's take it step by step. Do you have a phone? Good, let's leave it in your pocket for now. I'll tell you everything myself, and you write down on paper what matters to you. Shall I give you a pencil?"

Horst nods. Sara starts with the simplest thing. That between his medicine and him there is no longer a single form to fill. That the system sees him as a person with a name and a body, and both should work. That if something doesn't work — she, Sara personally, will stay here until he understands how to fix it. Not because she is required to. Because she knows what colour a ceiling can be at two in the morning.

| *That evening.*

In the evening Sara calls her daughter. Liza is eleven. Liza is in the Barcelona cluster on a student placement — studying hydroponics at an agricultural engineering school. Liza is talking about something to do with feeding basil. Sara listens.

Then Liza asks: "Mum, is it true that people used to kill each other because they had different passports?" Sara answers: "It's true." — "Why?" Sara is silent for about ten seconds. Then says: "Nobody remembers. It was a long story about fear."

Liza thinks. Then: "Mum, I was told about great-great-grandad Werner. That he knew all his neighbours. Was that hard?" — "What, hard?" — "Knowing all your neighbours." Sara smiles into the dark of her Berlin flat. "You know, darling, I think it wasn't hard. I think it was simply their life. They loved it."

Liza says: "There are eighteen people in my group. I know all of them." — "That's good," says Sara. — "That's very good."

End of the family story: Werner died in 1998, aged 68, in the same flat where he had lived his whole life. The whole staircase was at his funeral. Klaus died in 2031, aged 66, in a private hospice with automated care. There were four people at his funeral: Sara, her husband Jean-Paul, and two hospice employees. Sara is alive. She has a daughter, she has a job, she has the name of the neighbour upstairs (Magda, Bulgarian, moved in last year, brings flatbread on Tuesdays). Sara doesn't know when she will die or where. But for the first time in four generations, the Hauer family can say: tomorrow will probably look much like today. And today is fine. That is adult life. Not triumph. Not victory. Simply — fine.

MESSAGE TO POSTERITY

Why We Will Never Go Back

If you are reading these lines, then the experiment called "Rational Humanity" has officially entered the phase of full commercial deployment. The old world — with its endless wars over "sacred scraps of land" and cries of "national greatness" — remains for you only as a chapter in a history textbook: strange, frightening, and slightly absurd, like stories of the times when doctors didn't wash their hands before surgery.

You will ask us: "Why did you muck about for so long?" Why did we slaughter each other for centuries, with a whole planet's worth of resources beneath our feet?

The answer is simple and bitter: We were afraid. We were afraid to admit that behind our flags there was nothing except our own loneliness. We clung to borders the way children cling to the edge of a blanket in a dark room.

The Equation of Perpetual Peace

In 2037 we left you not an ideology, but a Mathematics of Equilibrium. Remember it:

$$P = \frac{I^c \times R^d}{F^{Id}}$$

Where:

P — (Peace) — system stability; when $P \rightarrow 0$ — war is inevitable

I^c — (Infrastructure Connectivity) — the level of infrastructural interconnection; the harder it is to "disconnect" us from each other, the less desire to "switch on" the guns

R^d — (Resource Distribution) — mathematically verified equity in distributing benefits

F^{Id} — (Ideological Friction) — the ideological friction coefficient; whenever it starts to rise — P falls towards zero. Check the calculator

Remember: as soon as F^{Id} begins to rise in your world — as soon as someone starts dividing people into "us" and "them" — the value of P (Peace) begins approaching zero. Don't listen to the orator. Check the calculator.

Your Greatest Privilege — Boredom

We left you a world that many will call "boring." In it there are no great battles, no "heroic sacrifices in the name of the nation," no planetary-scale drama. Value this boredom. It was bought at the cost of billions of our ancestors' lives. Your boredom is the highest form of civilisation.

Beware: Relapse

Remember that the "virus of politics" never completely dies. It sleeps in the dark corners of our biology, waiting for the moment you relax.

*"Earth is the cradle of the mind, but one cannot live in the cradle forever." —
Konstantin Tsiolkovsky*

- If the elevator breaks — fix the elevator, don't look for a guilty neighbour.
- If the energy runs out — build a reactor, don't take firewood from someone else.
- If you run out of space — fly to other worlds, but don't try to expand your room at the neighbour's expense.

* * *

We, the generation of 2037, are closing the door on the cradle.

We are leaving, bequeathing you a house in working order.

In it there are no "masters" and no "servants."

In it there is only you — the owners of your own destiny.

EARTH RESIDENTIAL COMPLEX

Handover protocol signed 3 May 2037.

Accepted for operation by humanity.

GLOSSARY OF ERC 'EARTH'

A brief dictionary for those who wish to speak the same language as the residents of the future

Every major reorganisation generates a new language. Below are the key terms of this book. Some come from political philosophy. Others were coined specifically to describe the new reality. All are used consistently throughout the text.

Terms of the ERC 'Earth' World

Earth Residential Complex (ERC 'Earth') —

The name of the new global governance system that replaced nation-states in 2037. The metaphor is intentional: the planet is a residential building, all people are residents, governments are management companies. A good management company fixes the elevators and removes the rubbish on time. A poor one takes the money and writes reports on why fixing the elevator is impossible.

Management Company —

The state, in this book's terminology. The deliberately bureaucratic name is designed to emphasise that the state does not exist in its own right, but to serve residents. When it stops fulfilling that function — residents have the right to dismiss it and hire a new manager.

Resident —

The citizen, in ERC 'Earth' terminology. After signing the 2037 Contract — a Skill-ID holder with the right to live and work at any point on the planet. The key difference from "citizen": the resident bears responsibility to the system (through their contribution and Skill-ID), but not to the flag of a particular state.

Simulacrum —

A false image of reality; an institution that has lost its function but retained its form. The term was introduced by French philosopher Jean Baudrillard. In the context of this book: simulacra are state structures that continued to exist after ceasing to fulfil their tasks. NATO by 2026 was a simulacrum of a military alliance. "Liberal democracy" in many countries was a simulacrum of popular will.

The Button —

Nuclear weapons as an instrument of political control. In Chapter 1 — the principal mechanism that held society together from 1945 to 1991. The threat of "pressing the Button" created fear, fear created discipline, discipline created collectivism. When the Button stopped frightening (due to drones and the changing nature of conflict) — the state's main argument for citizen loyalty disappeared.

Splinters —

Local conflicts or states whose ambitions are disproportionate to their contribution to global stability. Points of political friction capable of stopping the whole system. Israel, Taiwan, Ukraine as of 2026 — all described in the text as "splinters" which the Triad ultimately removed — not out of cruelty, but pragmatism.

Skill-ID —

The digital competence passport that replaced state citizenship in the ERC 'Earth' system. Verified by blockchain: real projects, outcomes, and peer evaluations are recorded. Cannot be forged. Determines the level of access to the system's benefits — instead of the colour of a passport cover. If you are the best welder in your sector, your Skill-ID opens the same doors as the chief architect's.

Apostles of Common Sense —

The group of engineers, economists, urban planners, and systems analysts who developed the conceptual basis of ERC 'Earth' in 2030–2037. The name is ironic: they were not preaching a new faith — they were proposing a new calculator. Their central thesis: managing the planet is an engineering task, not a political one. It is solved not by charisma but by formulas.

Dumbphone —

A keypad telephone without internet access. In 2024–2026 — an unexpected symbol of elite status and "digital detox." A person with a Nokia in a world of total smartphones looks like someone who can afford not to be reachable. The 25–40% rise in dumbphone sales among millennials and zoomers was one of the first indicators of the Great Disconnection.

Reservation —

A territory intentionally withdrawn from the digital network zone. In ERC 'Earth', Reservations are legally recognised "offline zones" where Skill-currency and global algorithms do not apply. Not a prison and not a zoo for technophobes — "the biological backup of civilisation" and a place for those who prefer "the weight of reality" to the comfort of an interface.

Survival Collectivism —

A form of social cohesion based on a shared external threat. Contrasted with "creative collectivism" (cohesion in pursuit of a shared goal). In Part I — one of the key mechanisms: the Cold War rested precisely on survival collectivism. When the threat vanished — this type of cohesion vanished too, without being replaced by the creative kind.

Political Friction ($P \times n$) —

The denominator in the ERC 'Earth' Universal Efficiency Equation ($E = I / P \times n$). The total of all approvals, vetoes, bureaucratic filters, and corruption levies standing between an idea and its realisation. The greater the political friction — the smaller the useful output at any level of funding. One of the book's central concepts.

The Triad —

The informal name for the three global "management companies" that dominated the period 2026–2037: the US (The Brand — meanings, finance, security), China (The Factory —

manufacturing, logistics, standards), Russia (The Engine & Shield — resources, energy, military deterrent). Not an official alliance and not a secret cartel — a structural inevitability that arose from the fact that three functions (protection, production, resources) became concentrated in three players.

Analytical Transition —

An authorial term for the short textual "bridges" between chapters, explicitly explaining the cause-and-effect relationship between topics. Used throughout this book so the reader understands: they are reading one continuous story, not a collection of separate essays.